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Assembly sets Jan 2027 deadline on CAG liquor audit action

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Legislative Assembly has directed the Government to submit an Action Taken Report (ATR) by January 31, 2027, on the findings of a Comptroller and Auditor General (CAG) audit that flagged revenue losses of ₹2,026.91 crore in the regulation and supply of liquor in the national Capital.

The directive follows the adoption of the Second Report of the Public Accounts Committee (PAC) on the CAG's performance audit of the excise system. The Assembly Secretariat has asked concerned departments to

review the recommendations and provide a status update as of December 31, 2026, within the fixed deadline.

Speaker Vijender Gupta described the move as a step to enforce accountability and ensure time-bound compliance with legislative oversight. He flagged systemic failures in the excise framework and called for prompt action on the PAC's findings.

A formal communication has been sent to the Excise Minister of the Delhi government and the Principal Secretary (Finance), asking them to initiate follow-up action and submit a comprehensive response. The direction places clear responsibility

on the executive to act within a defined timeline.

According to the PAC report, the audit found serious deficiencies in multiple areas, including regulation, licensing, pricing, quality control, and enforcement. These lapses, the report noted, resulted in significant revenue losses and raised concerns about governance and public health.

One of the key issues highlighted was the failure of the Excise Supply Chain Information Management System (ESCIMS).

The system was found ineffective in tracking liquor sales due to heavy reliance on the "stock take sold" method



and the existence of a large number of unaccounted barcodes. This created scope for revenue leakage.

The report also pointed out that the Excise

Intelligence Branch (EIB) module remained largely non-functional and was not effectively used for intelligence gathering. This weakened the enforcement frame-

work and limited the department's ability to act against violations.

The Speaker further noted irregularities in the licensing process. These included the non-production of records and the issuance of multiple licences to related entities.

The report also flagged a lack of clarity in defining Ex-Distillery Price (EDP) and Ex-Brewery Price (EBP), which led to discretionary pricing and undue benefits to license holders.

In addition, restrictive sourcing policies and weak demand assessment contributed to illegal activities such as liquor smuggling. Poor coordination between

departments and failure to use confiscation data effectively further worsened the situation. The report said enforcement agencies did not adequately respond to permit misuse or identify hotspots.

To address these issues, the PAC recommended a series of corrective measures. These include the expedited implementation of the e-Abkari portal with a robust track-and-trace system, improved barcode scanning and geo-tagging, and strengthening of the IT infrastructure.

The committee also called for filling gaps in the IT cadre, stricter scrutiny of licensing, and regular quarterly moni-

toring. It stressed the need for mandatory documentation and clearer pricing mechanisms, including a uniform minimum EDP and regulation of profit margins.

The Speaker emphasised the importance of fixing accountability for past irregularities and adopting a data-driven enforcement strategy. He said these steps are necessary to ensure transparency, efficiency, and long-term sustainability in the excise system. The Assembly's directive marks the beginning of a critical follow-up process. It aims to ensure that audit findings lead to concrete administrative action and measurable outcomes.

Police seek X user details in FSSAI defamation case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

In a fresh escalation of a high-profile social media expose, the Delhi Police has formally requested X (formerly Twitter) to furnish full identifying details of popular whistleblower-style accounts, including @khurpencch and @YTKDIndia.



The case stems from FIR No. 135/26, registered on or around March 24, 2026, at IP Estate Police Station under relevant sections of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS) for defamation and Section 72A of the Information Technology Act.

According to the police, multiple X handles posted posts with "malicious intent" that defamed a senior FSSAI officer identified in the posts as Sweetie Behera, damaged her reputation, and created public unrest by questioning her appointment.

The posts in question, dated March 9-10, 2026, were made by @khurpencch, a

vocal account known for exposing alleged irregularities in government recruitments, UPSC selections, and bureaucratic appointments and its sister handle @YTKDIndia.

In a detailed thread on March 10, @khurpencch directly addressed Behera, "Your name is Sweetie Bohra (Behera). You are posted as Director in FSSAI, but some people are raising questions on your appointment. In the recent selection process, your experience letter and CTC criteria were found deficient. How did you get selected?"

The thread highlighted three main allegations:

Discrepancy in experience: Behera's application claimed Nestlé India service from 2006 to 2020, but her service certificate reportedly showed she joined in August 2007, an 11-month shortfall.

Missing supervisory experience: The supervisory role was not supported by documents in her dossier. FSSAI allegedly granted relaxations in experience and CTC criteria despite rejecting other SC-category candidates for similar gaps. Recruitment Rules 2018 reportedly have no provision for such relaxations in CTC.

The account shared what it claimed were internal FSSAI recruitment committee documents flagging these issues and promised further exposés, stating, "Tomorrow four more people in FSSAI won't sleep."

An earlier March 9 post had listed Sweetie Behera among six FSSAI officials under scrutiny for alleged "incomplete and fake" ways of securing high-paying jobs.

The account vowed to continue, stating it had already given "hints" to FSSAI to

correct irregularities and that more revelations, including on the GST department, were coming. It received strong support from journalists and influencers who criticised the FIR as an attempt to suppress exposure of systemic issues.

The police letter marks the investigation's next step, identifying the real individuals behind the anonymous and pseudonymous handles.

Under Indian law, such Section 94 notices are routine in cyber-defamation and IT Act cases once specific posts are traced but real identities remain unknown. As of now, no charges have been framed against the account holders, and the matter remains under investigation.

The episode has once again spotlighted the tension between social-media whistleblowing and official responses to claims of irregularities in public appointments. Whether the documents shared were authentic stolen records (as alleged in the FIR) or legitimate public-interest evidence will be decided by the courts.

Delhi conducts civil defence mock drill with sirens, blackout

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi on Thursday carried out a large-scale civil defence mock drill across multiple locations in the city, with air raid sirens and blackout protocols implemented from 8 pm to test emergency preparedness.

The exercise was conducted under the supervision of the Directorate of Civil Defence in coordination with the Delhi Disaster Management Authority (DDMA), Delhi Police, the Indian Army, the National Disaster Response Force (NDRF), and other agencies.

Officials said the drill aimed to assess readiness in case of a hostile attack or an emergency situation. Authorities had issued prior advisories asking people to remain calm and cooperate with officials on the ground.

The mock drill was held at 10 identified locations across the city. These included the Irrigation and Flood Control



Building at the District Magistrate (East) complex, Raj Kumari Amrit Kaur College of Nursing, Kalka Apartments in Dwarka Sector 6, Taj Palace Hotel in the Diplomatic Enclave, Cantonment General Hospital, Madhukar Rainbow Children's Hospital in Malviya Nagar, The Mann School in Holambi Khurd, and sites in Karawal Nagar, Rohtash Nagar, Shastrri Park and Nand Nagri.

Officials said the exercise was planned after a coordination meeting held on April 1 with key stakeholders. A preparatory tabletop exercise was also conducted at

the District Magistrate's office complex in Nand Nagri to finalise operational details.

According to authorities, the primary objective of the drill was to evaluate how effectively agencies and civilians respond during emergency situations.

It also aimed to identify gaps in coordination, communication, and execution of safety protocols.

Residents were advised in advance that the drill was only a simulation and that there was no real threat. Authorities repeatedly urged people not to panic or spread rumours during the exercise.

Govt crackdowns on illegal LPG refilling

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government on Thursday conducted a crackdown on illegal LPG refilling in Alipur, uncovering unauthorised activities and registering a case against those involved, officials said. The action followed inputs from a sting operation aired on a national news channel on April 1. Acting on the information, a joint team of the Food and Supplies Department and Oil Marketing Companies carried out a raid at the identified location.

During the inspection, officials found that LPG cylinders were being illegally refilled at the premises. Authorities said such practices pose serious safety risks and disrupt the regulated supply of LPG. Three consumer passbooks were also recovered, which were allegedly being misused to obtain subsidised cylinders for illegal refilling and resale in smaller quantities. All materials linked to the illegal activity were seized at the site. An FIR has



been registered against the accused, and further investigation is in progress.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta reiterated the government's strict stance against black marketing and illegal diversion of LPG cylinders. She said the safety of citizens and the integrity of essential supply systems are non-negotiable.

The Chief Minister warned that any attempt to exploit consumers or manipulate LPG distribution will face strict action. She also assured that there is no shortage of LPG supply in the national capital. To strengthen enforcement, the government has approved the for-

mation of 13 district-level teams. Each team will be headed by the Sub-Divisional Magistrate and tasked with taking swift action against violations. These teams will coordinate with various departments and act on intelligence inputs and public complaints.

Officials said the move is aimed at improving monitoring and ensuring a quick response to illegal activities. The teams will focus on curbing hoarding, unauthorised storage, overpricing, and illegal resale of LPG cylinders.

The Government has also urged citizens to report suspicious activities. Complaints

can be lodged through designated helpline numbers between 9 am and 7 pm. Authorities assured that the identity of informants will be kept confidential and all verified complaints will be acted upon promptly.

In a step to ensure transparency, the government announced that daily press briefings will be held at 4 pm at Vikas Bhawan by the Food, Supplies, and Consumer Affairs Department. Citizens who are unable to attend can raise concerns through the helpline. Officials highlighted that illegal refilling not only affects fair distribution but also creates hazardous conditions due to unsafe handling and storage. Such activities increase the risk of accidents, including fires and explosions.

The government has directed enforcement agencies to intensify inspections across the LPG supply chain. This includes storage facilities, distribution agencies, transport networks, and retail outlets. Surprise checks will be carried out regularly to prevent violations.

Govt to set up animal welfare panels in all districts

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government has decided to establish Societies for Prevention of Cruelty to Animals (SPCAs) in all 13 revenue districts of the Capital, in a major step aimed at strengthening animal welfare enforcement at the grassroots level.

The move, approved under the leadership of Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, will place each SPCA under the respective District Magistrate (DM), ensuring direct administrative oversight and faster response to cases of animal cruelty. According to officials, the decision follows the recent reorganisation of revenue districts in Delhi.

The new structure is intended to improve the implementation of the Prevention of Cruelty to Animals Act, 1960, by decentralising authority and bringing enforcement closer to the ground.

Each district-level SPCA will include experts and members associated with animal welfare. These bodies will



be responsible for addressing complaints, monitoring violations, and ensuring that animal protection laws are enforced effectively.

The Chief Minister said that placing district magistrates at the head of these committees will make the system more responsive. She noted that cases of animal cruelty often require immediate attention, and a district-level mechanism will help ensure quicker action and better coordination among agencies.

The Chief Minister said the initiative is designed to strengthen institutional mechanisms and improve accountability. She added that the new framework will allow authorities to monitor

cases more closely and respond with greater efficiency. At the state-level, the Animal Welfare Board will function as the apex body overseeing all SPCAs. It will be responsible for monitoring implementation, providing technical guidance, and extending financial support to district units. This is expected to enhance the operational capacity of the SPCAs and ensure uniform standards across districts.

In a key structural change, the government has decided to dissolve the existing Delhi Society for Prevention of Cruelty to Animals (DSPCA).

Officials said this step is aimed at streamlining the system and avoiding duplica-

tion of roles. The new framework is expected to create a more coherent and efficient structure for animal welfare governance in the city.

The Chief Minister emphasised that the combined system of the Animal Welfare Board and district SPCAs will lead to tangible improvements in animal welfare outcomes. She said the Government is committed to building a system that is both effective and accountable.

Officials believe that decentralisation will help address long-standing gaps in enforcement. With dedicated committees in each district, authorities will be better equipped to handle complaints, conduct inspections, and take timely action against violations.

The move is also expected to improve coordination between local administration, veterinary services, and law enforcement agencies. By bringing all stakeholders under a structured framework, the government aims to create a more integrated approach to animal protection.

Over 8,000 commuters penalised, says DMRC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Filming reels, abusing and fighting have emerged as the most common offences in the Delhi Metro, with 2,468 commuters penalised between September and February. This was followed by unlawful entry into the women's coach, which saw 2,313 penalties.

A total of 8,251 penalties were imposed — 1,316 in September, 1,381 in October, 1,275 in November, 1,242 in December, 1,656 in January, and 1,381 in February — indicating stricter enforcement and varying commuter behaviour, an official said.

Nuisance-related violations, including filming reels inside trains, using offensive language, quarrelling and acts of indecency, remained consistently high throughout the period. Month-wise data showed 447 such cases in September, 357 in October,

410 in November and 408 in December, before rising to a peak of 501 in January and dropping to 345 in February.

Unlawful entry into women's coaches was the second most reported offence, with 2,312 penalties during the period, with January recording the highest at 559 cases, compared to 261 in September, 426 in October, 317 in November, 284 in December and 465 in February, the DMRC said.

Similarly, 2,249 commuters were penalised for sitting on the floor inside trains, the official said and added that the monthly figures stood at 408 in September, 395 in October, 287 in November, 345 in December, 394 in January and 420 in February.

Cases of spitting accounted for 767 penalties, with a gradual decline towards the end of the period, and there were 134 and 137 cases in September and October, respectively. The number rose



to 187 in November before dropping to 107 in January and 85 in February, he said.

Drunkenness led to 126 penalties overall, with figures fluctuating across months, he shared, and said the cases stood at 14 each in September and October, rising to 29 in November, followed by 22 in December, 23 in January and 24 in February.

Unlawful entry and walking on metro tracks resulted in 277 penalties, increasing from 42 cases in September to 61 in

January before easing to 40 in February, the official added.

In addition, 43 commuters were penalised for quarrelling, while nine cases were registered for carrying offensive materials, he said.

No instances of demonstration inside metro premises or travelling on the roof of trains were reported during the period, he added.

Overall, enforcement figures fluctuated across months. Most offences attracted a standard penalty of Rs

200, including nuisance, spitting, drunkenness, quarrelling and carrying offensive materials, he said, noting that nuisance and spitting cases formed a major share.

Higher penalties were imposed for serious violations, with demonstrations drawing ₹500, track trespassing ₹150, and unlawful entry into women's coaches ₹250, he added.

The Centre has proposed enhanced monetary penalties for various offences under the Metro Railways (Operation and Maintenance) Act, 2002, through the Jan Vishwas (Amendment of Provisions) Bill, 2026, aimed at strengthening deterrence while decriminalising minor violations. Under the proposed changes, offences such as drunkenness, nuisance, spitting, sitting on the floor and quarrelling may attract penalties of up to ₹2,500, replacing earlier provisions of lower fines.

PWD building decorative bird enclosure at Delhi Secretariat

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Public Works Department (PWD) is developing a large decorative bird enclosure at the entrance of the Delhi Secretariat.

The installation, coming up at Gate number 6, opposite the reception area, is designed to introduce a calming ambience through the gentle sound of birds.

"The structure is being crafted using a mix of three varieties of marble and mild steel, lending it both durability and visual appeal," an official said. As per the plan, the aviary is coming up in an open space beneath a road ramp, the enclosure is expected to be completed within a month.

Over the past few months, the department has taken up a series of maintenance and



refurbishment work across the complex, focusing not just on structural upkeep but also on improving the quality of shared spaces.

Located near the Indira Gandhi Indoor Stadium, the secretariat houses the offices of the chief minister, cabinet ministers and senior bureaucrats. However, the building has long faced challenges of limited space and fragmented office layouts, which often

affect administrative efficiency and employee comfort.

The ongoing upgrades, though modest in scale, reflect a growing recognition within the administration of the need for more conducive and engaging workspaces. By incorporating elements that reduce stress and enhance visual appeal, officials hope to create an atmosphere that supports productivity and well-being.

BJP not against Assam’s indigenous Muslims: Shah

TONY DAS ■ Guwahati

Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Thursday made it clear the BJP was not against the indigenous Muslims of Assam and was against infiltrators, as he accused the Congress of facilitating illegal immigration during its rule in the State. Addressing an election rally in Kaliabore for AGP’s Keshab Mahanta, he also asserted that the alliance between the BJP and the AGP was “like the Sun and the Moon”, and asked Congress leader Rahul Gandhi to stop day-dreaming that the partnership will end.

Shah alleged the Congress handed over the world-famous Kaziranga National Park to infiltrators who encroached on forest land and endangered the one-horned rhinoceros. “It was the NDA Government that evicted the encroachers and ensured Kaziranga was once again on the world tourism map,” Shah said.

Shah alleged that when infiltrators are removed from encroached land, the Congress tries to portray it



as faith-based politics. “The Congress settled infiltrators, and when they are evicted, the party tries to give a Hindu-Muslim angle to it. I want to make it clear that the BJP is against infiltrators and is not opposed to indigenous Muslims in Assam,” he said. Shah made the remarks following accusations from opposition parties that the BJP was polarising the people of Assam based on faith ahead of the Assembly elections. Alleging the Congress did

nothing for Assam’s development during its 15-year rule in the state, Shah targeted Rahul Gandhi, who is on a visit to the poll-bound northeastern state on Thursday, asking, “What did the party do for the State during its rule?” “Prime Minister Manmohan Singh represented Assam (in Rajya Sabha), but neither the then Central government nor the state government did anything for the state’s development,” he alleged. The Congress, when it

was in power at the Centre, gave only ₹1.28 lakh crore to Assam in 10 years. “But Prime Minister Narendra Modi gave ₹9.78 lakh crore to the state between 2014 and 2024,” Shah said. The Centre gave ₹1.35 lakh crore for infrastructural development, which included building highways, railways, waterways, airports, nine medical colleges and several engineering colleges, said Shah.

The Union home minister also pointed out that the prime minister took the initiative of setting up a ₹27,000-crore semiconductor chips facility at Jagiroad. “The BJP has taken steps to preserve the heritage of the state, constructed a memorial for the martyrs of the Assam agitation against foreigners, built an 80-feet statue of legendary Ahom general Lachit Barphukan and took his achievements to all corners of the country,” he said. Shah alleged the Congress did not honour Assam’s first Chief Minister, Gopinath Bordoloi, and eminent singer Bhupen Hazarika with the Bharat Ratna.

Parliament Budget Session to reconvene on April 16

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

The Budget Session of Parliament will reconvene on April 16 after a brief recess to pass bills to increase the number of Lok Sabha seats from 543 to 816 so that the women’s reservation law can be implemented at the earliest, in what is expected to be the latest flashpoint between the Government and the Opposition.

While the Government is keen on passing the bills, including amending the women’s reservation bill or Nari Vandan Adhiniyam, 2023, the Opposition has accused the Centre of trying to hurriedly move for passing amendments to take political advantage in the State elections. The two Houses will reconvene on April 16, with sources saying that the sitting will likely be for three days to take up the proposed legislations.

The Government is learnt to have conveyed to the opposition parties that the Houses are likely to meet for three days beginning April 16.

States Focus

Gujarat Local polls amidst sweltering heat

As Gujarat braces for rising temperatures this April, the political climate in the state is heating up alongside it with the announcement of elections to local self-government bodies. The State Election Commission has declared polls for 34 district panchayats, 260 taluka panchayats, 95 municipalities and 15 municipal corporations. The timing of the elections is being seen as strategically significant, as they precede the results of Assembly elections in other states scheduled during April-May. Political observers believe the State Government has opted for early local polls to insulate them from any potential adverse impact of results elsewhere. The ruling BJP, which has dominated local self-government institutions in Gujarat for over three decades, has swung into election mode.

Licenced liquor outlet approved in Porbandar

For over seven decades since Independence, Gujarat has remained the only state in the country to consistently enforce a policy of prohibition, rooted in its identity as the birthplace of Mahatma Gandhi, who strongly advocated abstinence from alcohol. The prohibition law has long been projected as a reflection of Gandhian ideals and a cornerstone of the state’s socio-political ethos. However, in a notable and pragmatic shift, the Gujarat Government has now granted permission for a licenced liquor outlet in Porbandar – the very birthplace of Mahatma Gandhi – marking a significant departure aimed at balancing tradition with modern economic and tourism needs. In a policy move cleared in March-April 2026, the state has approved the opening of a licenced liquor shop within a three-star or five-star hotel or resort in Porbandar.

West Asia crisis: Gas price hikes to ₹85

The ongoing conflict between the United States and Iran has begun to cast a shadow on Gujarat’s industrial growth, with the ceramic hub of Morbi facing a severe crisis due to a sharp rise in natural gas prices. The ceramic industry in Morbi, which has witnessed rapid growth over the years, is now under significant strain. Around 500 to 550 factories have shut down since mid-March, while the remaining 70-odd units that are still operational are also on the verge of closure as natural gas prices are set to double. According to the existing pricing structure of Gujarat Gas Company, industries consuming up to 50 per cent of allocated gas were supplied at ₹41 per unit (plus taxes). However, from April, the company has revised the indicative price to ₹85 per unit (plus taxes), marking a steep increase. The primary reason for the price hike is the massive surge in demand, estimated at around 70 lakh cubic metres of gas from Morbi alone. With propane gas currently unavailable, industries that earlier relied on propane are now shifting to natural gas, further intensifying demand pressures. At present, about 70 ceramic units remain operational and are dependent on Gujarat Gas for supply. Disruptions in the global supply chain due to the conflict have impacted fuel availability, prompting Gujarat Gas Company to initially curtail supply, forcing the Morbi ceramic industry to undertake a month-long shutdown.

CIC attempts to nip an immoral custom

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH ■ New Delhi

Imagine being a young girl in a remote village in Rajasthan. One day, your own father signs a piece of stamped paper, shakes hands with a stranger in front of the entire village, and hands you over for money. No wedding rituals, no legal papers that actually protect you, just a so-called ‘*Nata*’ (relationship) that treats you as property. This is ‘*Nata Pratha*’, a centuries-old custom still alive in pockets of Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh, Uttar Pradesh and

Gujarat, especially among certain tribal communities like the Bhils.

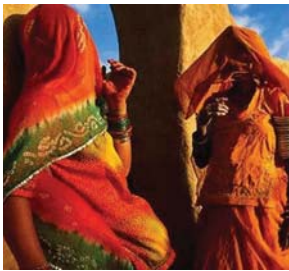
A custom rooted in poverty, patriarchy, and silence, *Nata Pratha* is often defended as tradition or local custom. In reality, it reduces girls and women to commodities. Families in extreme poverty see daughters as a source of quick cash. Men “buy” relationships without the legal responsibilities of marriage. There is no protection against abandonment, violence, or repeated sales. Girls, as young as teenagers, find themselves trapped in

informal live-in arrangements that society turns a blind eye to.

On April 2, 2026, this regressive practice came under fresh scrutiny when the Central Information Commission (CIC) ordered the Union Ministry of Women and Child Development to disclose an important Action Taken Report (ATR) it had submitted to the National Human Rights Commission (NHRC). Information Commissioner PR Ramesh, in a clear and firm order dated February 25, 2026, in the case of RTI applicant Tillesh

Bhadala, directed the ministry to revisit the RTI request and share the report, after redacting any personal or exempt details under Section 8(1)(j) of the RTI Act.

A father in Rajasthan sold his minor daughter under *Nata Pratha* for ₹2.5 lakh. The deal was signed on stamp paper in front of villagers on July 11, 2019. The buyer paid ₹60,000 upfront; the rest was due later. When he didn’t pay in time, the father took the girl back and fixed her *Nata* with another man for just ₹32,000. The terrified girl resisted. She com-



plained to the police that her alcoholic father had been trying to sell her repeatedly to earn money and had even threatened to kill her. Tragically, she later died by suicide in June 2020.

The NHRC’s own investigation found this was not an isolated case. On June 6, 2024, the Commission took

women and needed to be abolished. Yet, the ministry initially denied everything, claiming it involved personal information of complainants and families, exempt under the RTI Act.

The CIC agreed that personal details of victims must stay protected, but drew a clear line: the overall action taken report is a matter of public interest. It is not about exposing individuals; it is about holding the system accountable. Information Commissioner Ramesh ordered the ministry to provide a redacted version of that report within 30 days, free of cost. The NHRC has rightly pointed out that it has

no legal sanctity. Yet it continues because of deep-rooted social acceptance in certain rural pockets, weak enforcement of existing laws like the Prohibition of Child Marriage Act, POCSO and trafficking laws and fear of speaking out.

The CIC’s order is a small but powerful victory for accountability. By forcing the disclosure of what the government has or hasn’t done, it opens the door for public scrutiny, media attention, and pressure on authorities.

But today, thanks to one RTI applicant and a vigilant Information Commissioner, a little more light has been thrown on the darkness.

FROM PAGE - 1

SC fumes over gherao of judicial officers

The court directed the Election Commission to requisition and deploy adequate central forces at locations where judicial officers have been assigned to adjudicate objections under the SIR process. The court also directed the investigative authority to submit a preliminary report directly.

As many as 700 judicial officers from West Bengal, Odisha and Jharkhand are deployed in the ongoing SIR process to deal with over 60 lakh objections of those who are excluded from the voter lists during the SIR process. The bench, also comprising justices Joyimalya Bagchi and Vipul M Pancholi, directed the Chief Secretary, the Director General of Police and the Chief Electoral Officer of West Bengal to submit a compliance report in pursuance of its directions.

“Additionally, the Chief Secretary, the DGP, the District Magistrate, Malda and the Superintendent of Police, Malda, are also directed to show cause as to why suitable action should not be taken against them in light of the letter received from the Chief Justice of the High Court,” it ordered.

The CJ directed all the top officials to appear before it online on April 6, when the bench will take up the pleas, including the one filed by Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee.

Responding to submissions of the Advocate-General of West Bengal that the poll panel should not be acting as an adversary in this matter, the CJ said, “Unfortunately, in your State, each one speaks political language, and this is the most polarised State. You are forcing us to make observations. Do you think we are not aware of who the miscreants are? I was monitoring everything till 2 am. Very, very unfortunate.”

The apex court took suo motu cognisance of a letter from the Chief Justice of the High Court detailing a harrowing night where judicial officers, including three women and a five-year-old child, were held captive by a mob for over nine hours without food or water.

The incident occurred during the SIR exercise in the Kaliachowk area of Malda district, and as per the order, seven judicial officers were gheraoed by “anti-social elements” at a BDO office starting at 3:30 pm on Wednesday. During the hearing, the CJ referred to the “shocking” timeline of the incident and said that at 3:30 pm, the gherao began, and the Registrar General of the high court informed the State authorities immediately. He went on and said that till 8:30 pm, despite repeated pleas, no tangible action was taken by the state officials, he said.

“Nothing, however, was done till 8:30 pm. The Registrar General then contacted the Home Secretary and the DGP. Assurance was made for early action. But no action was taken by the authorities. Even food and water were not permitted to be supplied to the judicial officers,” the order noted. The Chief Justice of the High Court was forced to intervene personally, placing group calls to the Home Secretary and DGP. The Home Secretary and the DGP arrived at the CJ’s residence, and the judicial officers, who were held hostage, were relieved post-midnight.

Even after the rescue, the judicial officers’ vehicles were pelted with stones and attacked with sticks and bricks, the CJ said. “Shockingly, when the judicial officers were released around midnight and were returning to their respective places of stay, their vehicles were pelted with stones and attacked with bamboo sticks and bricks. In this light, the Chief Justice has strongly deprecated the delay on the part of the civil and police administration in taking appropriate action,” he said. “Till 11 O’clock, your Collector was not there. I had to verbally instruct very harsh orders in the night,” the CJ said.

BJP RAPS TMC

“It is sad that Mamata Banerjee, who has taken the oath of the Constitution, is taking judicial officers hostage in a blatant defiance of the Supreme Court orders. The intention is to scare the judicial officers as Mamata Banerjee wants to obstruct the SIR process,” he added.

Bhatia alleged that Banerjee deployed her party workers to take the judicial officers “hostage” to protect the Rohingyas.

“Mamata Banerjee, who is supposed to protect the people of West Bengal and their rights, is standing by the Rohingyas. She lo

Energy crisis: India flags concerns at UK-led talks

India reiterated that de-escalation and a return to diplomacy remain the only viable path forward. Misri called for dialogue among all stakeholders to restore stability in the region and ensure the safety of commercial shipping routes.

Earlier, the Ministry of External Affairs had confirmed India’s participation in a separate UK-led initiative involving around 35 countries aimed at exploring options to reopen the Strait. The discussions include key global players such as France, Germany, Italy, Canada and the United Arab Emirates, although the United States is not participating. The initiative follows remarks by US President Donald Trump urging countries dependent on the Strait to take responsibility for securing it. British Prime Minister Keir Starmer has said the efforts will focus on diplomatic and political measures, alongside exploring practical mechanisms such as mine clearance and protection of oil tankers. The outcome of these deliberations is expected to shape coordinated global action to restore maritime security and stabilise energy markets. Earlier, Iran continues to strike Israel and Gulf countries: Iran responded defiantly to Trump’s speech, in which the American president claimed US military action had been so decisive that “one of the most powerful countries” is “really no longer a threat”. A spokesman for Iran’s military, Lt. Col. Ebrahim Zolfaghari, insisted Thursday that Tehran maintains hidden stockpiles of arms, munitions and production facilities. He said facilities targeted so far by US strikes are “insignificant”.

Just before Trump began his address — in which he said US “core strategic objectives are nearing completion” — explosions were heard

in Dubai as air defences worked to intercept an Iranian missile barrage.

Less than a half-hour after the president was done, Israel said its military was also working to intercept incoming missiles. Sirens sounded in Bahrain, home to the US Navy’s 5th Fleet, immediately after the speech.

Attacks continued across Iran on Thursday, with strikes reported in multiple cities.

In Lebanon — home to Iran-backed Hezbollah militants who are fighting Israel, which has launched a ground invasion — an Israeli strike killed four people in the south, the Health Ministry said.

More than 1,900 people have been killed in Iran during the war, while 19 have been reported dead in Israel. More than 20 dozen people have died in Gulf states and the occupied West Bank, while 13 US service members have been killed.

More than 1,200 people have been killed and more than 1 million displaced in Lebanon. Ten Israeli soldiers have also died there.

Congress hand in glove with BJP: Mamata

“I strongly ask everyone not to attack any judge on behalf of any political party,” Mamata asserted, maintaining that such acts give Bengal a bad name. She claimed that some political outfits were acting as stooges of the BJP and trying to divide minority votes.

“If they feel so much pain for the minorities, why don’t they speak up when migrant workers from Bengal face atrocities in other states or when people’s names get deleted in SIR?” she asked. Addressing a poll rally in Baishnabnagar, the TMC supremo vowed to drive the BJP out of the State first and then from Delhi, while alleging that the Election Commission is running the administration despite an elected government. “It is my promise, I will drive out the BJP first from Bengal and then from Delhi,” Mamata said at an election rally.

She accused the poll body of acting at the BJP’s behest, alleging development work in the state has stalled. “The EC has doomed Bengal at the behest of the BJP; development work has stopped in the state,” Banerjee, who has repeatedly accused the poll body of being hand in glove with the saffron party, said.

“(Prime Minister) Narendra Modi and (Union Home Minister) Amit Shah have taken the country on the path to ruin,” she said.

Claiming that names were deleted from voter lists during the ongoing Spec.

Simian scare has apex court looking for succor

The scope of work includes providing trained personnel to safely deter monkeys and prevent nuisance or safety risks within the designated residential and institutional premises.

“The bidder/tenderer must have at least one (1) running work contract in any Central/ State Government Organisations or Public Sector

Undertakings (PSUs) for engaging a minimum of 50 personnel/ manpower for Monkey Chasing/ Handling/ Repelling Manpower,” the tender document said.

And it’s not just the Supreme Court or Delhi High Court. In the past, monkeys have terrorised the prime minister’s office, torn apart the Home ministry’s files, and created a menace at former Vice President Venkaiah Naidu’s official residence. Monkeys are usually seen, amidst screams of surprises from unsuspecting passers-by, roaming around in the corridors of power in the Capital, though several calculated attempts have been made to rehabilitate them outside Delhi. Landmark judgments have been passed, expert committees have been formed, and government tenders have invited agencies to sterilise the simians, but nothing seems to have worked. The monkeys have even been relocated to wildlife sanctuaries, but they always find their way back. They hop tall buildings, destroy vegetation and gardens, and enter homes fearlessly for food.

Experts have long advocated for non-violent deterrence methods, habitat restoration, and better waste management to reduce such conflicts. By mandating trained handlers and adherence to animal welfare laws, the initiative signals a step toward more responsible and compassionate urban wildlife management. A lack of consensus between wildlife experts and animal activists on how to solve the monkey menace creates a deadlock. Delhi woke up to its monkey problem in 2007. In October, Surinder Singh Bajwa, then-deputy mayor of Delhi, fell to his death from his balcony after a monkey attacked him.

The New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC) had installed life-size cut-outs of grey langurs on roads along the Central Ridge in an attempt to keep rhesus macaques, colloquially known as rhesus monkeys, away from transit routes and venues during the G20 Summit in 2023. The civic body also deployed 40 trained workers who will mimic the sound made by grey langurs in an attempt to keep monkeys away from hotels and G20 Summit-related venues.

Tejas likely to resume flights from next week

The IAF had also ordered a comprehensive scrutiny of the jets following the accident.

On delays in delivery of Tejas Mark 1A variant to the Indian Air Force (IAF), Sunil said the HAL will be ready to deliver over 20 jets by December and that six of them could be supplied soon as the final tests of radar, avionics and missile-firing systems were currently underway.

The delivery of the jets is facing delays primarily due to GE Aerospace missing several deadlines for the supply of its F-404 aero engines to power the jets. To a question on the IAF flagging certain issues relating to the performance of the jets, the HAL CMD said a project review committee in May is expected to clear the jets for deliveries.

US defence major GE Aerospace has delivered

five jet engines to HAL, and the sixth one is expected to be supplied in the next few days.

It is also learnt that the HAL has imposed penalties under the provision of Liquidated Damages on GE Aviation for the delay in deliveries of the engines for the Tejas Light Combat Aircraft Mark 1A. The penalties are being imposed on GE Aerospace as per the contract. In February 2021, the defence ministry sealed a ₹48,000 crore deal with HAL for the procurement of 83 Tejas Mk-1A jets for the IAF. The defence ministry in September last year sealed another deal worth ₹62,370 crore with the HAL to procure 97 Tejas Mk-1A light combat aircraft for the IAF.

Tejas is a multi-role fighter aircraft capable of operating in high-threat air environments. It has been designed to undertake the air defence, maritime reconnaissance and strike roles.

The IAF is looking at inducting the warplanes as the number of its fighter squadrons has gone down to 29 from the officially sanctioned strength of 42.

Mittal to replace Chadha as AAP dy leader in RS

Once considered a close confidant of Kejriwal and among the youngest MPs in the country, Chadha had played a key role in party affairs, particularly in Punjab and during the AAP’s tenure in Delhi. However, things have changed in recent months.

Chadha was abroad for medical reasons when Kejriwal, the then Delhi chief minister, was arrested in connection with the excise policy case in March 2024. He remained away during Kejriwal’s nearly six-month incarceration and met him only a few days after his release on September 13, 2024. More recently, Chadha maintained silence when Kejriwal, former deputy chief minister Manish Sisodia and other AAP leaders were discharged by a Delhi court in the excise case last month. He also missed Kejriwal’s press conference and a rally at Jantar Mantar following the court’s relief.

Party leaders claimed Chadha has been increasingly sidelined from political campaigns and organisational matters of the party in other States, although he has been vocal inside and outside Parliament, raising issues such as high air fares and the condition of gig workers.

Talking to reporters, Mittal said the party’s national convener has entrusted him with the role of AAP’s deputy leader in the Rajya Sabha, and he will discharge his duties sincerely and present both the party’s stance and national interests forcefully in the House.

The AAP currently has 10 members in the Rajya Sabha, including seven from Punjab and three from Delhi. Chadha has been part of AAP since its inception. An alumnus of Delhi’s Modern School, he is a chartered accountant. Chadha met Kejriwal towards the last leg of the India Against Corruption movement when Kejriwal and others were debating whether or not to start a party. At 23, Chadha came on board as AAP was formed, and his first political task was to draft the Delhi Lokpal Bill.

Ganderbal encounter under scrutiny after youth killed

MOHIT KANDHARI ■ Jammu

The recent encounter between a joint team of security forces and terrorists in the Central Kashmir district of Ganderbal has come under the scanner after allegations surfaced that it was a 'fake' encounter in which one local youth was killed.

According to local reports, Rashid Ahmad Mughal from the Chountwalliwar area of Ganderbal was killed in an overnight encounter in the Arahama area.

Soon after the identity of the deceased terrorist was established by the local police authorities the family members alleged their son was killed in a 'fake' encounter claiming he had no links with the terrorists.

The family also demanded an investigation. "We are approaching the police to register a case. We want a complete investigation and justice," said Aiyaz Ahmad,

brother of the deceased killed in the encounter.

The matters became worse after Chief Minister Omar Abdullah also jumped in and demanded a transparent and time bound probe in the matter on Thursday.

Former Chief Minister and PDP Chief Mehbooba Mufti also claimed that allegations are being raised that the recent encounter in Jammu and Kashmir's Ganderbal district, in which a local terrorist was gunned down, was "fake".

Chief Minister Omar Abdullah posted on X, "I believe the claim of the family should not be dismissed out of hand. At the very least this encounter needs a transparent & time bound probe with the facts made public. Any attempt to obfuscate or delay the announcement of a probe will only damage credibility & that is not in anyone's interest".

Speaking to reporters here, Mehbooba said, "There was



Security personnel during an inspection in Ganderbal, Jammu and Kashmir on Wednesday

PTI

an encounter in Arahama in which a 29-year-old local youth, Rashid Mughal, was killed. There are allegations that it was a fake encounter. The Army first said he was a foreign militant, then they said he was a local linked to militancy." The PDP chief also

claimed that Rashid ran an NGO. "Even his body was not handed over to the family. He was buried in Baramulla. This is what is happening with our youth," the former J-K chief minister said.

In Ganderbal, Ajaz Ahmad, brother of the deceased

Rashid Ahmad Mughal, told reporters that he had left home on Tuesday morning but didn't return.

"He left home in the morning and didn't return home. Yesterday, the local police were asked to identify the body and it was found

out that it was my brother," he said. Ajaz said that his brother had no link with militancy. "We are shocked to hear this. He was totally innocent and he has been killed," he said.

Earlier, Srinagar based Chinar Corps Wednesday posted on X "During the night of 31 Mar 26, the cordon was tactically reorganised amidst the intermittent firing under-way. Own troops effectively retaliated with a calibrated response resulting in one terrorist eliminated".

"A joint search operation was launched by the Indian Army and

Jammu and Kashmir Police in the general area, Arahama, of Ganderbal. During the search, vigilant troops observed suspicious activity. On being challenged, terrorists opened fire and own troops retaliated. Operation is in progress," Chinar Corps posted on Tuesday after the encounter was started.

Vidya Bharati helped shape NEP 2020 curriculum, says Pradhan



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan on Thursday said Vidya Bharati has served as an important reference point for the Government in shaping the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020 and asserted that many of its practices have now been incorporated into the national curriculum.

Addressing a programme of Vidya Bharati here at the beginning of the new academic year, Pradhan said, "Although Vidya Bharati represents only around one per cent of the larger education ecosystem, that one per cent is like a drop of nectar."

He added that, "It has shown what the standards of education should be, what learning outcomes should be, what competencies should be, how teaching should happen, and what values should be imparted."

Pradhan said he has been associated with the education department for the last five years, and Vidya Bharati remained a "successful reference point" whenever decisions were taken on textbooks, medium of instruction, language or social development.

"Whether it is textbooks, medium of instruction, language, or social development, I have considered Vidya Bharati to be a successful reference point," he said.

The Union minister said the Government, under the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, introduced NEP 2020 and that Vidya Bharati was among the inspirations behind it.

"I can say with confidence that Vidya Bharati has been one of the inspirations behind the National Education Policy. The values, skill development methods, and teaching practices of Vidya Bharati have now been incorporated into the national curriculum," he said.

India-Bangladesh discuss boosting defence ties, regional cooperation

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

M Riaz Hamidullah, Bangladesh's High Commissioner to India, met Chief of Army Staff Uppendra Dwivedi in the national capital on Thursday, with both sides exploring ways to strengthen bilateral defence cooperation, including joint training initiatives.

According to sources, "at the meeting, both sides underlined the important role played by the two Armed Forces in forging understanding and stabilizing the relations between Delhi and Dhaka in the context of wider bilateral relations, particularly during recent times of strained ties."

The interaction focused on expanding collaboration

between the militaries while identifying avenues to promote peace and stability in the region. The Indian Army said the discussions reflected a shared commitment to deepening strategic engagement and enhancing mutual understanding through institutional partnerships.

The meeting comes amid a broader push by both nations to reinforce their historically close ties. Earlier, Union Minister of State for External Affairs Kirti Vardhan Singh reiterated India's support for Bangladesh's new Government, emphasising that the relationship between the two neighbours is rooted in shared history, culture and language.

Speaking at Bangladesh's Independence Day celebrations in New Delhi, he noted that the legacy of the 1971



Aptitude for National Advancement) Saptah from April 2 to 8.

Mishra said that governance today requires new capabilities to respond to technological disruptions, climate change, urbanisation, and global uncertainties, adding that continuous learning strengthens innovation, adaptability and professionalism, while mindset and empathy remain critical to effective public service.

He also said that Sadhana Saptah reinforces the shift towards a capable, committed and citizen-centric civil service. Referring to the integration of training institutions across the country, Mishra said the CBC has added coherence and

scale to the ecosystem.

CBC Chairperson S Radha Chauhan said the concept of 'Karmayogi' reflects a public servant who combines wisdom with action and delivers governance with empathy and contextual understanding.

Sadhana Saptah provides an opportunity for officers to reconnect with their core purpose of service and renew their commitment to citizen-centric governance, she said.

Rachna Shah, Secretary, Department of Personnel and Training (DoPT), said that Mission Karmayogi has brought a fundamental transformation in capacity building over the past five years.

Liberation War continues to shape bilateral ties, fostering a partnership built on trust, shared values and a common vision for regional prosperity.

India has also expressed its intent to further strengthen cooperation with the new administration led by Tarique Rahman. External Affairs Ministry spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said New Delhi is keen to expand engagement across sectors, including connectivity, trade and capacity-building initiatives.

With ongoing collaboration in infrastructure, energy and cross-border projects, both countries are looking to advance a resilient, people-centric partnership while maintaining dialogue on all aspects of bilateral engagement.

ED raids I-PAC executive, AAP's Vijay Nair in West Bengal coal scam case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Enforcement Directorate (ED) on Thursday conducted fresh searches against an executive of political consultancy firm I-PAC, former AAP communication in-charge Vijay Nair and some others in connection with an alleged coal "scam" of West Bengal, officials said. The raids are being undertaken at locations in Bengaluru, Hyderabad, Mumbai and Delhi under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA), they said.

The premises of I-PAC co-founder and director Rishi Raj Singh in Bengaluru and Vijay



Govt seeks private support for Khelo India, no job quotas

The Government is making efforts to involve private companies in the Khelo India mission for the promotion of sports, but there is no directive on them for job reservation of sportspersons, the Rajya Sabha was informed on Thursday. Replying to a supplementary question during the question hour in the Upper House, Minister of State for Youth Affairs and Sports Raksha Nikhil Khadse said providing employment for sportspersons in the private sector is entirely at the discretion of companies.

"There is no such policy at present. It is at the discretion of the private companies that if they want to absorb a sportsperson, they can employ the sportsperson," she said.



Nair in Mumbai are among those covered, they said. The federal probe agency conducted raids in this case in January at the I-PAC office as well as at the Kolkata residence of its founder and one of the directors, Pratik Jain. Singh and Jain were recently summoned by the ED to record their statements. They

have approached the Delhi High Court to quash these notices issued to them, citing ongoing election work in West Bengal and Tamil Nadu.

The ED case stems from a November 2020 FIR of the CBI that alleged a multi-crore rupee coal pilferage scam related to Eastern Coalfields Limited mines in West Bengal's Kunustoria and Kajora areas, in and around Asansol.

The agency had said in a statement that a hawala operator linked to this alleged coal smuggling ring had facilitated transactions of tens of crores of rupees to Indian PAC Consulting Pvt. Ltd., the registered company of I-PAC.

PM urges governance update to match changing times

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Thursday stressed the need to continuously update governance with the rapidly changing times to ensure ease of living for citizens.

Highlighting that the core mantra driving the country's administration today is "Nagrik Devo Bhava" (treating citizens as supreme), he said that public service is being reoriented to be more capable and sensitive to the needs of citizens.

"Governance is now being given a new identity by making it truly citizen-centric," Modi said in a video message at the launch of 'Sadhana Saptah'.

The prime minister said that governance must be the benchmark for improving ease of living and quality of life for citizens, and urged public servants to learn something new every day. "Our governance should ensure that the quality of life of citizens improves day by day. This is our true benchmark," he asserted.

Calling for a fundamental shift in administrative culture, Modi pointed out that the old system placed excessive emphasis on being an 'officer',



whereas the country's focus today is firmly on the spirit of duty. "Before every decision, when you think about what your duty demands, the impact of your decisions will automatically multiply many times over," he said, addressing public servants.

India is advancing swiftly amidst fast-changing global systems, and it must continuously update its governance machinery, the prime minister said.

Reminding public servants that for the common citizen, the local Government office is the face of the entire Government, Modi said that the working style and behaviour of officials directly shape public trust in democracy and constitutional institutions. "Whatever we do, at whatever level, we must safeguard that trust; it is the foundation of our democracy," the prime minister said.

Central employees to complete competency courses annually

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

All central Government employees have been mandated to complete competency-linked courses relevant to their role or level on a dedicated online platform annually, which will reflect in their annual performance appraisal reports, the Rajya Sabha was informed on Thursday.

The Government has adopted a competency-based capacity building approach, focusing on role-based learning, continuous

skill development, and alignment of training with role requirements, Union Minister of State for Personnel Jitendra Singh said in a written reply.

"The Department of Personnel and Training (DoPT) has mandated all central Government employees and officers of the all-India services to complete competency-linked courses mapped to their role/level and comprehensive assessments prescribed by their ministries/ departments/organisations (MDOs) or cadre controlling author-



ities (CCAs) on iGOT (integrated Government online training) portal annually, which is to be also reflected in their annual performance appraisal reports (APARs)," he said.

The minister was responding to a query about the Government's plans to incorporate competency-based scores for promotion and appraisal processes of its employees.

A framework of roles, activities and competencies (FRAC) aims to align all positions in Government with clearly defined roles, activities, and required competencies (behavioural, functional, and domain), Singh added.

In a separate reply, the minister said that details of the engagement of consultants are maintained by respective ministries and departments.

The General Financial Rules (GFR), 2017, administered by the Department of Expenditure, Ministry of Finance, provides for the

fundamental principles applicable to all ministries or departments concerning the engagement of consultants and external professionals or consultancy firms for specific jobs, he said.

"As informed by the Department of Expenditure, data regarding engagement of consultants is maintained by respective ministries and departments," Singh said.

The minister was asked the year-wise number of consultants engaged by all the central ministries and departments during the last five years.



States Focus



ANAND SHARMA URGES INDIA TO LEAD GLOBAL SOUTH FOR PEACE

Amid the escalating West Asia conflict, senior Congress leader Anand Sharma urged India on Thursday to take the lead in mobilising the Global South and strategic-partner countries to collectively work towards the restoration of peace and order in the region. In a statement, the former Union Minister also called for national unity and said a mature response guided by national interests is the need of the hour. “The world cannot remain a mute spectator to the collapse of a rule- based multilateral order and global crisis management mechanism. India has throughout history commanded respect for its moral authority and commitment to peace. There is much at stake, especially the future of the younger generation.



ELECTION SQUAD INSPECTS KANIMOZHI CAR AHEAD OF POLLS

In continuing crackdown on the movement of unaccounted cash and prohibited items ahead of the Tamil Nadu Assembly polls, an election flying squad on Thursday intercepted and inspected the vehicle of DMK MP Kanimozhi Karunanidhi in Sivaganga district. The Deputy General Secretary of the DMK was on her way to attend a series of campaign meetings in the region when her convoy was stopped at a designated check post by the Flying Squad Team (FST) and Static Surveillance Team (SST) personnel. The team conducted a thorough search of the Member of Parliament’s vehicle and other cars in her entourage, said sources. Visuals of the incident showed the officials checking the trunk and baggage within the vehicle as the DMK leader waited.

DMK leader jabs AIADMK over BJP tie, targets Palaniswami

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Manamadurai (Tamil Nadu)

DMK leader Kanimozhi on Thursday took a swipe at the AIADMK over its alliance with the BJP, saying its leader Edappadi K Palaniswami would face the same fate as JD(U) chief Nitish Kumar, and wanted the party “at least” in the Opposition.

The Lok Sabha MP, addressing a public meeting here for the April 23 polls, claimed it was not a mere Assembly election but a battle between “Keeladi and Nagpur, the headquarters of RSS.”

She was referring to the Keeladi archaeological excavations in this district, and claimed the findings have



DMK Deputy General Secretary and MP Kanimozhi Karunanidhi, greeting the gathering during an election campaign in support of party candidate for Manamadurai constituency in Sivaganga district

proven the heritage value of Tamil, which the “BJP does not want to accept.” She said Chief Minister and DMK President MK Stalin had asked the Centre to accept the report of the findings, which it has not.

“They (BJP-led Centre) didn’t

accept it since that would reveal the significance of Tamils and the Tamil race to the world. The BJP cannot accept it; (a Government) which keeps imposing Hindi on Tamil Nadu, gives pittance as allocation for Tamil com-

Congress, BJP and Akalis will be wiped out from Punjab in 2027 polls: CM Mann



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Fazilka

Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann on Thursday said that the people of the state will “wipe out” Congress, BJP and the Shiromani Akali Dal in the 2027 Assembly elections for their “decades of loot, lies and betrayal”.

Addressing a public gathering after laying foundation stones and inaugurating development projects worth Rs 283.99 crore in Fazilka, Mann said traditional parties have no future in Punjab as people have made up their mind to reject them.

He alleged that these parties had repeatedly “backstabbed Punjab” and misled people with hollow promises, but voters are now fully aware of their “dubious character”.

“The people will not forgive these parties and will teach them a befitting lesson again in 2027,” he said.

Shah calls Adhikari a shortcut to bring change in West Bengal

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Thursday turned BJP leader Suwendu Adhikari’s nomination filing from Bhabanipur into a high-voltage political spectacle, saying he had a “shortcut” to bring about “*paribartan*” (change) in West Bengal: defeating Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee in her own constituency.

Shah said while the BJP would otherwise have to win 170 seats to form the Government with a comfortable majority, a victory for Adhikari in Bhabanipur alone would automatically bring change to the State’s politics.

Addressing a rally ahead of a massive roadshow from Hazra Crossing in south Kolkata before accompanying Adhikari for his nomination filing, Shah framed the Bhabanipur contest not merely as another assembly seat battle but as the symbolic centrepiece of the BJP’s campaign to unseat the Trinamool Congress Government in the 2026 West



Union Home Minister Amit Shah, during a roadshow for filing of nomination papers by BJP candidates Suwendu Adhikari from Bhabanipur in Kolkata, West Bengal on Thursday

Bengal assembly elections.

“Change will happen in West Bengal. But should there be a change in Bhabanipur or not?” Shah asked the crowd.

“With folded hands, I appeal to the people of Bhabanipur that, for the liberation of the entire State, ensure a massive victory for our candidate Suwendu Adhikari,” he said.

Shah said he had personally persuaded Adhikari to contest from Bhabanipur, the chief minister’s pocket borough, instead of limiting

himself to his traditional bastion of Nandigram.

“Suwendu-da wanted to contest from Nandigram. I told him, not just Nandigram. You have to enter Mamata Banerjee’s home and defeat her there,” Shah said.

He reminded the audience that Banerjee, despite returning to power in 2021, had lost in Nandigram to Adhikari, who defected to the BJP in December 2020 after being one of her closest aides.

“She formed the Government in Bengal, but

she lost in Nandigram to Suwendu Adhikari. This time she will lose not only in the entire State, but in Bhabanipur too,” Shah asserted.

Bhabanipur has been Banerjee’s political citadel for over a decade. She first contested from the seat in 2011 and became the chief minister, defeating the Left Front. After losing Nandigram in 2021, she returned to the assembly through a bypoll from Bhabanipur, winning comfortably and re-establishing the constituency as her safest political turf.

By fielding Adhikari against Banerjee in Bhabanipur, the BJP is seeking to recreate the drama of Nandigram in the heart of Kolkata and turn the contest into a direct prestige battle between Bengal’s two most recognisable political faces.

The symbolism was underlined as Shah and Adhikari stood together atop a campaign vehicle during the roadshow from Hazra crossing, with saffron flags lining the route and supporters chanting slogans calling for “*paribartan*” in Bengal.

Priyanka Gandhi calls LDF PM Modi’s ‘B-team’ in Kerala

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Thiruvananthapuram

Congress MP Priyanka Gandhi on Thursday accused the ruling LDF in Kerala and Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan of being Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s “B-team”.

Priyanka, speaking at a corner meeting in Puthanthopu here as part of the Congress-led UDF poll campaign for the Kerala assembly elections, alleged that Modi “bowed down” before the US and Israel in

connection with the West Asia conflict, and as a result created a situation where India will also suffer along with other nations.

She also alleged that Modi’s policies have not provided safety and security to Indians stranded in the Gulf region during the conflict there.

Priyanka also accused the LDF and Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan of being Modi’s “B-team”.

“Think about it. Name one leader who has stood up and expressed himself or



herself against Narendra Modi and not been attacked either by the Enforcement

Directorate, the Income Tax department, the CBI or his other agencies,” she said.

TVK chief Vijay seeks justice in Karur stampede case, film release

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Tiruchirappalli (Tamil Nadu)

Tamilaga Vетtri Kazhagam (TVK) chief Vijay on Thursday alleged joint machination and conspiracy in the tragic stampede in Karur and also in the release of his final film ‘*Jananayagan*,’ and said that he too wanted justice in the Karur incident. The tragic stampede left 41 people dead and several injured at a rally addressed by the actor-politician on September 27, 2025.

Addressing an election rally after filing his nomination papers from Tiruchirappalli East Assembly constituency, Vijay said, as many have been insisting, the Karur incident was “a joint machination.”

“I, who have come to ask justice for you, also want justice,” the Tamilaga Vетtri Kazhagam chief said and also claimed a conspiracy over the release of his last film *Jananayagan*.

He flayed both the Centre and the State Government’s on the LPG cylinder shortage and said both the Governments could have averted the crisis had they planned ahead and regulated.

“Tamil Nadu Chief Minister M K Stalin air dashes to Delhi if there’s a raid or some issue in the



TVK chief and candidate from the Tiruchirappalli East constituency, Vijay, during a roadshow en route to filing his nomination for Tamil Nadu Assembly elections in Tiruchirappalli

family. Has he rushed to the national capital to resolve the LPG cylinder crisis?” Vijay asked and said the unpreparedness has led to a shortage of gas cylinders, leading to the closure of tea shops and even hotels.

“This has caused hardship and losses to many. Had they been vigilant and taken precaution then the crisis would not have escalated. Both are responsible for this,” he said.

In a lighter vein, he remarked, if one asked “Stalin sir” about this crisis, he would say it has no connection whatsoever. “But if there’s a raid or problem in his house, then he would fly to Delhi,” Vijay said, and the crowd cheered at the remark.

He appealed to the people not to believe the DMK or BJP as both were on the same page. These parties should

Karnataka CM slams BJP for favouring the rich

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Davanagere (Karnataka)

Karnataka Chief Minister Siddaramaiah on Thursday launched a sharp attack on the BJP, accusing it of “favouring the rich”, while asserting that his Government stands firmly with the poor.

Interacting with reporters after a campaign event in Davanagere South constituency, Siddaramaiah said the BJP subscribes to an economic model that benefits the wealthy, while the Congress Government is committed to welfare measures aimed at uplifting the underprivileged.

“There are two economic theories — Trickle down theory and Universal Basic Income theory. BJP supports trickle-down-meaning they favour the rich. While we believe in Universal Basic Income, which supports the poor,” he said. The CM said the public response to the ongoing campaign had exceeded expectations and reflected growing awareness among voters.

“In the campaign, people are responding beyond our expectations. People have realised that the BJP, despite



being in power for four years, did nothing,” he said, alleging that the previous Government “carried out no development work and only looted the State.”

Defending the Government’s flagship guarantee schemes, Siddaramaiah said they have been implemented successfully over the past three years and have restored public confidence.

“Every year, we are spending around ₹52,000 crore. Up to March 31, ₹1.31 lakh crore has been spent. So there is no question about these schemes-we will continue them,” he said, dismissing the BJP’s claims that the programmes would bankrupt the State.

Poll Tracker survey indicates DMK likely to win 172-178 seats



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Chennai

The DMK-led alliance is projected to retain power with a sweeping majority in the upcoming Tamil Nadu Assembly elections, according to a survey released by Poll Tracker on Thursday.

The survey predicts a clear edge for the front, forecasting it to secure between 172 and 178 seats in the 234-member house.

The primary Opposition, led by the AIADMK, is projected to lag significantly with 46 to 52 seats.

The DMK-led bloc is expected to garner 42.7 per cent of the total votes. The newly formed Tamilaga Vетtri Kazhagam (TVK), led by actor-politician Vijay, is projected to make a notable debut with a 19.2 per cent vote share, translating to 6 to 12 seats. Meanwhile, the NTK is expected to secure between 0 and 2 seats with 5.1 per cent of the vote share.

The poll analysis indicates that the alliance between the AIADMK and the BJP has contributed to a consolidation of minority votes against the AIADMK-led front. It further notes that multiple communities, including the Mudaliar, Naidu, and Muslim communities, are broadly inclined toward the DMK alliance.

Poll Tracker is an election analytics platform that provides longitudinal data through a tracking methodology to monitor shifts in public sentiment over time.

Kerala LDF unveils manifesto, pledges jobs, welfare hikes

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kozhikode (Kerala)

Kerala’s ruling LDF on Thursday unveiled its Assembly election manifesto, promising to eliminate absolute poverty, raise welfare pensions to ₹3,000, and boost jobs and investment. The CPI(M)-led alliance also pledged to increase women’s workforce participation, expand skill training, and attract ₹2 lakh crore in investments over five years.

Speaking after releasing the document, Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan said the plan aims to combine social



Kerala Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan

justice with economic growth while transforming the State into a knowledge-based economy.

The Left Government had recently announced that

extreme poverty had been eliminated in the State and the welfare pension increased from ₹1,600 to ₹2,000.

In its current manifesto,

the LDF says it plans to identify around five lakh poorest families and help them rise above poverty through targeted support.

Special focus will be given to vulnerable groups such as the Scheduled Castes, fisher-folk, and ‘*Antyodaya*’ (old age) beneficiaries.

The LDF also promised better care for the elderly and bedridden patients.

Welfare pensions are set to be increased to ₹3,000 per month, and efforts will be made to ensure proper healthcare and support systems at the local level, the manifesto said.



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Order Order

HC seeks Maharashtra Govt's response to plea against move to cancel 5 pc quota for Muslims

Mumbai: The Bombay High Court on Thursday directed the Maharashtra government to respond to a petition challenging its decision to cancel five per cent reservation in education and jobs for the Muslim community.

A bench of Justices RI Chagla and Advait Sethna asked the state government to file its response through an affidavit in three weeks and posted the matter for further hearing on May 4. The petition filed by advocate Syed Ejaz Abbas Naqvi challenged the government resolution (GR) of February 17 issued by the Department of Social Justice and Special Aid of Maharashtra, terming it as being violative of the Constitution and against the interests of the Muslim community.

Naqvi called the government's move "racial discrimination". "The respondent (Maharashtra government) is practicing racial discrimination with the persons of a minority community i.e. the Muslim community. This is in violation of the fundamental rights enshrined in the Constitution," the plea said, adding there is no rationale behind the government's decision to scrap the quota.

As per the plea, in July 2014, the then Congress-NCP government had announced a 16 per cent reservation for the Maratha community and a five per cent quota for Muslims in government jobs and education, placing them under the Socially and Economically Backward Class category.

The ordinance giving effect to this decision was challenged in the HC, which struck down the reservation for jobs but allowed the five per cent quota for the Muslim community in education, the plea said.

As per the February 17 GR, all previous decisions and the ordinance related to the five per cent reservation in government and semi-government jobs and educational institutions for the socially and educationally backward Muslim group, included under the Special Backward Category (A), have been cancelled. The government has cancelled the earlier decisions and circulars from 2014 and stopped issuing caste and non-creamy layer certificates to Muslims in the Special Backward Category, the new order said.

Special MP/MLA court halts trial against Gauriganj MLA

Sultanpur (UP): The Special MP/MLA Court here on Wednesday stayed proceedings against Gauriganj MLA Rakesh Pratap Singh in a case of alleged assault on a local BJP leader inside a police station. Special Magistrate Shubham Verma on Wednesday ordered a halt to the trial after the defence submitted a copy of a directive from the Allahabad High Court.

Advocate Ravivansh Singh Pankaj, appearing for the defence, told the MP/MLA court that on March 17, the high court had stayed proceedings in the case until further orders on a petition filed by co-accused Prashant Singh.

The court has fixed April 16 as the next date of hearing. The case pertains to an incident on May 10, 2023, when Deepak Singh, husband of municipal council chairperson Rashmi Singh, was allegedly assaulted inside the Gauriganj police station. An FIR was lodged against then Samajwadi Party MLA Rakesh Pratap Singh and 12 others. Following an investigation, police filed a chargesheet against the legislator and nine other accused, officials said.

Singh was expelled from the Samajwadi Party in 2025 for working against party principles. He is currently an Independent MLA from Gauriganj.

No tree felling in Mussoorie sans permission: Uttarakhand HC

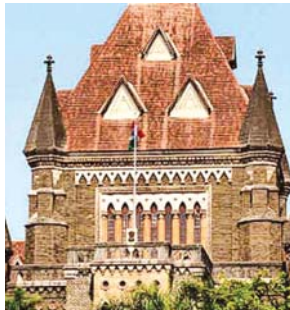
The Uttarakhand High Court directed the Mussoorie municipality not to cut down any trees without obtaining required permission from the forest department, and asked the state government to file their responses in this matter. A division bench of Chief Justice Manoj Kumar Gupta and Justice Subhash Upadhyay was hearing a petition on Wednesday that some Oak trees in a notified forest area in Mussoorie's Husain Ganj.

This was being done as part of a road widening work by the municipality, said the petitioner, Pravesh Singh Rana. The court directed all parties to file their responses within three weeks.

The government informed the court that during an inspection conducted by the forest range officer of Mussoorie on March 13, it was discovered that four Oak trees and three other trees had been illegally felled without obtaining valid permission from the competent authority.

Challans have been issued against the concerned individuals, cases pending against them, and an investigation is currently underway, it said. The municipality informed the court that road widening has been halted pending the completion of the investigation into the matter.

The court directed that no trees shall be cut down without obtaining permission from the competent authority. The next date of hearing for the case has been fixed for April 27.



SC tells SEBI to close Sandesara Brothers' case

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court told market regulator Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) on Thursday to close proceedings against Sterling Biotech Limited (SBL) and its promoters, Chetan and Nitin Sandesara, or else it will be compelled to take a serious view of the matter.

A bench of Justices JK Maheshwari and AS Chandurkar told the SEBI's counsel that its order of November last year was very clear that all proceedings against the Sandesara brothers will be quashed if they deposit ₹5,100 crore in the apex court registry.

"We have said all proceedings, including that of SEBI, need to be quashed upon deposit of the money. If you are doing it, then it is alright, or we will be compelled to pass a detailed order on the issue," the bench told the counsel.

The SEBI's counsel said Solicitor General Tushar Mehta is deliberating with the market regulator and sought a week's time to apprise the court of the developments.

Senior advocate Mukul Rohatgi, appearing in the

court for the Sandesara brothers, said the SEBI has till now refused to close the proceedings and that it has to take a call on the issue of quashing the proceedings in compliance with the apex court's order.

The bench posted the matter for further hearing on April 10 and noted that Mehta, who is in deliberation with the SEBI on the issue, will apprise the court of the developments on the next day of hearing.

The SEBI is probing allegations that the promoters of SBL had secured loans from foreign banks and routed funds into the company as purported investments that could mislead investors and distort the true financial position of the company.

On November 19 last year, the top court accepted a settlement proposal under which the Sandesara brothers agreed to deposit ₹5,100 crore as a full-and-final settlement of claims arising from these proceedings.

The amount was deposited in the court registry in December 2025, following which the court gave effect to its earlier order for quashing of proceedings.

Last month, a consortium of secured lenders, including



banks of the SBL of promoters Chetan and Nitin Sandesara, moved the top court for the disbursal of their claim amounts from the ₹5,100 crore deposited in the apex court registry, while highlighting that their total outstanding against the business group's companies was ₹19,283.77 crore.

The banks, which are 20 in number of the 26 secured creditors of the SBL, placed on record a consolidated computation of claims across multiple group entities and setting out the methodology adopted for the distribution of the amount.

The application of the consortium, however, stated that a few lenders are yet to formally confirm their acceptance, although their dues have been computed on the same basis.

On March 25, the bench noted that the total lender banks are 26 in number and out of the said list of banks, serial numbers one to 20 have submitted their claims and all relevant documents proportionate to their respective shares that have been specified in the chart.

It noted that six banks have not submitted the formal affidavit and required

documents, including Krung Thai Bank Public Company Limited (Singapore), Hua Nan Commercial Bank (Singapore), Taiwan Co-operative Bank, The Shanghai Commercial and Savings Bank Limited, HDFC Bank and Aviral Maritime Infra.

"Thus, retaining the share with respect to their claims, the amount of the banks at Serial Nos. 1 to 20 be released immediately in terms of column 5 of Annexure A-4," the bench had said, adding that the interest accrued on the deposit lying with the bank with respect to the sum of the lender banks at

Delhi HC directs removal of derogatory, vulgar song by Honey Singh, Badshah

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court on Thursday took a strong exception to a "vulgar" and "derogatory" song allegedly released by rappers Yo Yo Honey Singh and Badshah in 2006, saying the track was in complete disregard of even the minimum standards of civility and directed its removal from online platforms.

Justice Purushendra Kumar Kaurav said the court's conscience was shaken to its "absolute core" and that the dissemination of the song on platforms accessible to minors cannot be countenanced under the guise of artistic freedom and free speech in a society governed by the rule of law.

Justice Kaurav said he heard the song in his chamber and thought that it lacked any artistic or social value, and reduced women to objects of ridicule.

"The title of the song can't be dictated in the order. The same seems to



be completely unacceptable. "The court finds that the song is grossly vulgar, obscene and derogatory towards women... Lyrics are not only disrespectful and offensive but also ex facie dehumanising and normalise the treatment of women as objects of ridicule and sexual gratification," said the court.

The court noted that the song, allegedly released in 2006 by the rappers under their collaboration "Mafia Mundeer", has been uploaded by various users on social media and has garnered millions of views.

The court issued notice to

Honey Singh and Badshah on the petition by Hindu Shakti Dal on the issue and directed the rappers as well as any other person claiming rights in the uploaded song or its version to take it down from online platforms. "The court finds that allowing dissemination of the said song on public platforms, which are accessible to minors, cannot be countenanced in the guise of artistic freedom and free speech. The song is in complete disregard of the minimum standard of civility," the court said.

The petitioner's counsel said that although both

rappers have denied singing the song, Honey Singh sang verses of it at a concert in Delhi, which further sparked the controversy over the song's creation.

During the hearing, the court said the song cannot be permitted to remain on social media and has to be taken down.

The court directed the Centre to issue the necessary directions to take down any other URL to the song provided by the petitioner.

It listed the case for hearing on May 7.

The petitioner said that in 2006-2007, Honey Singh and Badshah did an "underground" release of the song, which has objectionable and vulgar lyrics, and provokes violence towards females.

The plea said that being celebrities with an enormous fan following, Honey Singh and Badshah should take responsibility and issue a public apology for the song. The petition sought directions for the removal of the song from YouTube and Spotify.



SC cancels Satinder Singh Bhasin's bail in Venice Mall case

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Thursday set aside the bail granted to businessman Satinder Singh Bhasin in connection with a multi-crore rupee alleged Grand Venice Mall scam in Greater Noida.

A bench comprising Justices Sanjay Karol and NK Singh directed Bhasin to surrender before the local authorities within a week.

"The petitioner has not complied with the conditions of bail imposed upon him vide order dated November 6, 2019. Resultantly, the bail granted to the petitioner is cancelled. The petitioner to surrender within one week from the date of this judgment," the bench said.

The top court directed that Bhasin may apply for regular bail afresh after a period of twelve months, subject to fully complying with the orders passed in the insolvency proceedings.

Insolvency proceedings were invoked against Bhasin's companies under the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code, 2016.

"It is directed that the passport of the petitioner is not to be released by the Trial Court without the leave of this Court," the bench said.

The apex court also forfeit-

serial numbers one to 20 be also proportionately distributed to them in accordance with the share of their claims.

It had further said that the amount with respect to the banks at serial numbers 21 to 26, which is retained, shall be kept in fixed deposit on an auto-renewal basis separately and distributed on the submission of their claims.

"The interest accrued on the sum of the remaining six banks be also kept in fixed deposit, in addition to the amount of their proportionate share," it had said.

On the SEBI's proceedings against the Sandesara brothers, the top court on March 23 said the solicitor general may seek instructions on the issue and also on the closing of every other issue.

The banks had earlier told the court that the lenders had decided to aggregate all domestic and foreign currency exposures, convert foreign loans into rupees at a fixed exchange rate of ₹63 per US dollar — reflecting the average rate in 2015, when most accounts turned non-performing — and apply a uniform interest rate of 9 per cent per annum from the date of NPA, with annual rests.

ed ₹50 crore plus the accrued interest deposited by Bhasin as part of the bail condition.

"We direct that out of the aforesaid amount, ₹5 crores plus proportionate accrued interest be transmitted to the National Legal Services Authority for its utilisation in achieving its objectives.

"The remaining amount, along with proportionate accrued interest be transmitted to the IRP for the purposes of the IBC proceedings. The Registrar (Judicial) of this Court to ensure immediate compliance by the concerned Trial Court in disbursal of the above amounts," the bench said.

The top court had, in November 2019, granted Bhasin, the director of Bhasin Infotech and Infrastructure Private Limited, bail in these cases subject to various conditions. Around 46 FIRs were registered against several people in connection with the alleged scam in which investors claimed that they were duped by the accused when handing over the plot of land.

The FIRs, registered in New Delhi and Uttar Pradesh, were filed by the allottees of units in the project against the petitioner, alleging non-delivery of their units, siphoning of their funds, and impropriety in allotment of land with the collusion of state officials.

DMRC not bound to revive terminated agreement: NCLAT

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

In a relief to Delhi Metro Rail Corporation (DMRC), appellate tribunal NCLAT has said that DMRC is not bound to revive the concession agreement with Pratibha Industries Ltd (PIL) for a multi-level parking at one of its stations.

Earlier, on July 30, 2024, NCLT had approved a resolution plan for PIL by a consortium of Crown Steels and Sunrise Industries. As per the plan, DMRC was required to revive the concession agreement in favour of PIL in full force and effect without any additional lia-



bility towards the bidder.

After approval of the plan, the successful bidder approached NCLT seeking directions against DMRC.

"We therefore direct the Applicant/SRA (successful bidder) as well as DMRC to take all the necessary steps

in terms of the approved Resolution Plan for the effective implementation of the resolution plan in question," NCLT said in a September 11, 2025 order.

DMRC had filed objection before NCLT, questioning the jurisdiction of the insol-

veny tribunal. However, it was rejected. Following this, it moved the National Company Law Appellate Tribunal (NCLAT).

NCLAT in its order dated March 27 observed that since the concession agreement with PIL was terminated on September 1, 2017, much prior to the initiation of insolvency proceedings against the firm, DMRC is not bound to revive the agreement.

The concession agreement between the two parties was for a multi-level parking with commercial development at the New Delhi Railway Station-cum-Airport Terminal of Airport Express Line.

Amit Jogi convicted in 2-decade-old murder case

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Bilsapur

Nearly 23 years after the murder of NCP leader Ramavtar Jaggi, the Chhattisgarh High Court on Thursday convicted former CM Ajit Jogi's son Amit Jogi in the case, and directed him to surrender within three weeks, the CBI's counsel said.

A trial court had in 2007 acquitted Amit Jogi, president of the Janata Congress Chhattisgarh (J), founded by his late father.

The HC, however, reopened proceedings in the 2003 murder case last month following directions from the Supreme Court on an appeal by the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI).

The SC in November last year said though the CBI had filed the application after a significant delay, it was equally true that "the charges against respondent Amit Jogi were very grave, involving a conspiracy to murder a member of a rival political party".

On Thursday, a division bench of Chhattisgarh High Court's Chief Justice Ramesh Sinha and Justice Arvind Kumar Verma set aside the acquittal of Amit Jogi, convicted him and issued the surrender directive, CBI counsel Vaibhav A Goverdhan told PTI.

Reacting to the HC's order, Amit Jogi said injustice was done to him as he was previously acquitted and now declared guilty without being



allowed to be heard. He expressed hope that the truth would prevail and that he would get justice from the Supreme Court.

"Dear friends and well-wishers, today the Hon'ble High Court accepted the CBI's

appeal against me in just 40 minutes, without giving me an opportunity to be heard. I regret that a person who had been acquitted by a court has now been declared guilty without even a single chance for a hearing. This has

never happened before," he said in a post on X.

"The court has given me three weeks to surrender. I believe a grave injustice has been done to me. I have full faith that I will receive justice from the Supreme Court. I have complete trust in the judicial system and will move forward with peace, faith, and patience. Truth will ultimately prevail," he added.

On the other side, Satish Jaggi, son of the late Ramavtar Jaggi, welcomed the HC verdict, saying, "Truth has won."

"Today is Hanuman Jayanti. I bow before Lord Hanuman. I have received his special blessings. My family's 20-year-long penance has borne fruit today. My faith in

the judiciary has been vindicated. Truth has prevailed and my father has finally received justice," he told reporters here.

He thanked those who supported him and stood by justice and truth throughout this journey.

"The main accused, Amit Jogi, will now go to jail. While our family cannot truly be happy because we lost our father, justice has been served. I express my gratitude to the judiciary and the CBI. Today, truth has won," he added.

Nationalist Congress Party (NCP) leader Ramvatar Jaggi was shot dead in Raipur on June 4, 2003, when Ajit Jogi was the chief minister of Chhattisgarh.



Editor's
TAKE

Will anti-incumbency matter in Kerala poll?

With Kerala CM Pinarayi Vijayan seeking a third consecutive term, the critical question is if anti-incumbency real this time, or is it being overstated?

Kerala the most literate state of all, is going to the polls on April 9, 2026. Just a week away, yet there is no clarity on voters' preferences and what they actually have in mind when they vote. Kerala has a simple electoral matrix - the United Democratic Front (UDF) and Left Democratic Front (LDF) have ruled the state, alternating each time. But this rhythm was broken in 2021 when Kerala's Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan took the oath of office for his second consecutive term and has gone on to rule the state for an unprecedented ten-year tenure. What people voted for was his strong governance credentials-welfare delivery, and crisis management during floods and the COVID-19 pandemic.

But the last five years have not been very smooth for the LDF; the challenges are mounting - with ever-growing unemployment and deteriorating law and order, people are weighing their options of finding an alternative. There is little doubt that anti-incumbency sentiment exists. Independent surveys suggest that nearly half the electorate desires change. Centralised decision-making, governance lapses, and the state's financial stress have dented the government's image. Delays in welfare payments, corruption charges, and administrative inefficiencies have further eroded its image. But what goes in LDF's favour is that Kerala's voters are discerning; dissatisfaction does not automatically translate into regime change unless the opposition presents a credible alternative. For the UDF, this election is both an opportunity and a challenge. It benefits from latent anti-incumbency and has demonstrated organisational resilience, particularly in recent local body polls. However, its perennial weakness-internal factionalism-continues to undermine its prospects. Leadership tussles and disputes over candidate selection dilute its message, while the perception of lacking a coherent developmental vision persists. This time around, the presence of the BJP-led NDA, which, though limited, has the potential to split anti-LDF votes in closely contested constituencies. The issues shaping voter choices in 2026 go beyond traditional welfare politics. Economic distress is central, with youth unemployment exceeding 15 per cent and migration continuing unabated, people are looking for a change. Additionally, identity and regional issues-ranging from church disputes to human-wildlife conflicts-add layers of complexity to electoral behaviour. So this is not going to be a single-issue election on anti-incumbency but a layered one, and it is hard to predict the voters' minds. Most surveys point to a razor-close contest, with seat projections overlapping significantly between the LDF and the UDF. What emerges clearly is the absence of a decisive wave.

So, is anti-incumbency real? Yes, but it is neither uniform nor overwhelming. It is issue-specific, local rather than pan State. This makes the election less a referendum on the government and more a constituency-by-constituency contest. In a state known for its political maturity, the verdict is likely to be finely balanced - decided not by sweeping sentiment but by a host of issues that may be haunting the voters' minds.

Bihar prohibition: A decade of dry law

From mounting revenue losses and thriving illicit trade to shifting patterns of substance abuse and limited social gains, prohibition has delivered a mixed legacy. What began as a social reform now demands a deeper, more honest evaluation



ABHINAY
NARAYAN

On April 5, 2016, Bihar embarked on an ambitious and morally charged experiment, complete prohibition. Conceived as a transformative social reform aimed at curbing alcohol abuse, empowering women, and fostering public health, the policy was hailed as a bold assertion of political will. Ten years on, however, the moment calls less for celebration and more for introspection. Has prohibition delivered on its promises, or has it unravelled into a complex web of unintended consequences?

The origins of this policy lie in the political churn of 2015, when Chief Minister Nitish Kumar, responding to sustained demands from women's groups, pledged to enforce a complete ban on alcohol if returned to power. True to his word, the government implemented prohibition in phases-initially on April 1, 2016, followed by a comprehensive ban on April 5. Rooted in Gandhian ideals and Directive Principles of State Policy, the move carried both moral and constitutional resonance.

Yet, the policy marked a dramatic reversal from the state's earlier fiscal strategy. In 2005, Bihar's budget stood at a modest ₹27,000 crore, with limited revenue streams. To augment income, the government had expanded liquor retail aggressively. The number of liquor outlets rose from 3,436 in 2006-07 to 5,467 in 2012-13, with rural areas witnessing an increase of over 200 percent. Consequently, excise revenue surged from ₹500 crore in 2006 to nearly ₹6,000 crore by 2015. Alcohol had, in effect, become a fiscal mainstay. Prohibition, therefore, came at a steep economic cost. In 2015-16, Bihar earned ₹3,142 crore from excise duties. Within a year of the ban, this plummeted to a mere ₹46 crore, and by 2017-18, it was virtually nil. The state is estimated to have suffered an annual revenue loss of around ₹4,000 crore since then. Meanwhile, neighboring states such as Jharkhand and West Bengal reaped indirect benefits. Jharkhand's excise revenue rose from ₹912 crore in 2015-16 to ₹1,600 crore in 2017-18, while West Bengal's collections climbed from ₹4,014 crore to ₹5,781 crore over the same period. The implication is evident: demand did not disappear-it merely crossed borders. Legally, the Bihar Prohibition and Excise Act was among the most stringent in the country. Early provisions included collective fines and even the arrest of all adult family members in a household where alcohol was found. Over time, however, the law underwent three amendments, softening its harshest edges. First-time offenders can now be released upon paying fines ranging from ₹2,000 to ₹5,000. These revisions reflect the



ESTIMATES
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COMPLIANCE.

administrative and ethical challenges inherent in enforcing such a sweeping ban. Despite the rigidity of the law, illicit trade has flourished. The persistence of bootlegging networks and recurrent tragedies involving spurious liquor underscore a critical failure of enforcement.

Rather than eliminating consumption, prohibition appears to have driven it underground, exacerbating risks to both law enforcement and public health. Equally concerning is the shift in patterns of substance abuse.

A 2017 pilot study conducted by a team of doctors revealed that over 25 percent of habitual drinkers turned to alternatives such as toddy, cannabis, and hashish following the ban. Data from the Narcotics Control Bureau corroborates this trend. Seizures of cannabis in Bihar rose dramatically from 14 kilograms in 2015 to 10,800 kilograms in 2016, and further to 27,395 kilograms by 2021-an increase of nearly 2,700 percent. Similarly, hashish seizures, which were negligible in 2015, climbed to 115 kilograms in 2016 and 363 kilograms in 2021. These figures suggest not a decline in addiction, but its mutation into other, often more insidious forms. The state's response to rehabilitation has been, at best, modest. Plans to establish de-addiction centres across all 38 districts, each with a capacity of 10 beds, amount to a total of just 380 beds. This is manifestly inadequate for a state grappling with widespread substance dependency, raising questions about the comprehensiveness of the policy framework. From a social standpoint, the results are equally ambiguous. One of the principal objectives of prohibition was to reduce domestic violence and improve women's safety. Yet, data offers little evidence of substantive progress. The proportion of women experiencing domestic violence rose marginally from 40.2 percent in 2015-16 to 40.6 percent in 2019-20. Reported crimes against

women also increased from 13,891 cases in 2015 to 17,950 in 2021. These trends underscore a crucial point: deep-rooted social issues cannot be resolved through a singular legislative intervention.

Moreover, prohibition has had a disproportionate economic impact on marginalised communities. Sections such as the Mahadalits, who were traditionally engaged in the production of local liquor, lost a vital source of livelihood. Instead of integrating these groups into alternative economic frameworks, the policy inadvertently pushed them further to the margins, raising concerns about equity and social justice.

Even today, prohibition remains more aspirational than absolute. Estimates suggest that nearly 17 percent of men (NFHS-5 Data) in Bihar continue to consume alcohol, indicating persistent gaps in enforcement and compliance. This disconnect between policy intent and ground reality reveals the inherent limitations of prohibition as a tool of governance. In conclusion, Bihar's decade-long experiment with prohibition stands as a compelling case study in public policy. It reflects the tension between moral aspiration and practical governance, between political will and societal complexity. While the intent behind the policy was undeniably noble, its outcomes have been mixed, if not contradictory.

The way forward lies not in rigid adherence or outright abandonment, but in recalibration. A nuanced approach-combining regulation, awareness, robust rehabilitation mechanisms, and economic alternatives for affected communities-may prove more effective. Bihar's experience serves as a reminder that complex social challenges demand equally sophisticated and adaptive solutions. Policies, after all, must ultimately be judged not by their intent, but by their impact.

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PIC TALK



NASA's Artemis II moon rocket lifts off from the Kennedy Space Center's Launch Pad 39-B.

PHOTO: PTI

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A toolkit to survive the AI gold rush



RACHNA
LAKHPATRI

2ND OPINION

There is a particular kind of madness that visits human civilisations every few centuries. It visited us during the dot-com frenzy of the late 90s, and it is visiting us now — dressed in a sharp blazer, carrying a pitch deck, and calling itself Artificial Intelligence.

Walk into any boardroom today. Sit through any investor call. Scroll through any LinkedIn feed. The word "AI" has become less of a technology descriptor and more of a survival incantation. Stamp it on your company, and doors open. Forget to mention it, and you are already yesterday's business. Every second startup claims to be an AI company the way every second person in the 2000s claimed to be a dot-com entrepreneur. We have seen this film before. We just never seem to remember how it ends.



There is something deeply revealing in this pattern — not in the technology itself, but in our relationship with it. Human beings have always been seduced by the promise of a tool that thinks faster, scales better, and costs less than the inconvenient, emotional, lunch-break-taking human. The tragedy is not that we build such tools. The tragedy is that we build entire economies around the hype of such tools, long before the tools actually deliver. The numbers quietly tell a sobering story. A significant chunk of AI startups being born today will not survive their third year. Many will be acqui-hired — that polished corporate term for "we bought your team and buried your product." The rest

will exhaust their Series A funding chasing a product-market fit that was never really there, then quietly fold. What remains standing will largely be the same five or six tech behemoths who had the infrastructure to absorb the innovation in the first place.

But here is the question that keeps this from being just another market analysis — what are we leaving behind for the generation currently in school? A child entering Class Six today will graduate into a workforce that looks nothing like the one being described in career counselling sessions right now. The jobs being prepared for may not exist. The skills being drilled may already be automatable. And yet, the conversation about futures, about meaningful careers, about what it means to contribute — that conversation is still largely absent. The AI bubble, if it bursts, will leave debris. But the deeper damage will not be economic. It will be existential — a generation handed a world shaped by tools they were never taught to question, only to use. Perhaps the real intelligence we need — artificial or otherwise — is the wisdom to ask not just 'what' AI can do, but 'who' it is ultimately doing it for. That answer still requires a very human mind.

The Pioneer
SINCE 1865

The writer is a spiritual teacher and a popular columnist

ILLEGAL KIDNEY RACKET EXPOSES MEDICAL ETHICS FAILURE

The recent kidney racket scam uncovered in Kanpur is deeply shocking and raises serious concerns about the misuse of medical facilities and the exploitation of poor and vulnerable people. Following a dispute over just Rs 50,000, a massive illegal kidney transplant racket was exposed, leading to the arrest of six individuals, including five doctors allegedly involved in conducting illegal transplants.

The case came to light when a financially distressed student who had agreed to sell his kidney reported that he was paid less than the promised amount after surgery. His complaint unexpectedly led to the exposure of a large illegal organ transplant network operating in Kanpur. Investigations revealed that the

racket targeted economically weak youth through middlemen and social media platforms, while patients were arranged through contacts at dialysis centres.

Reports suggest that illegal transplants were conducted on several individuals, including foreign nationals, with organs being sold for huge amounts of money. Health authorities have initiated action against the hospitals involved and legal proceedings have been started under relevant laws.

This incident highlights the urgent need for stricter monitoring of transplant procedures and stronger action against illegal organ trade.

YASH PAL RALHAN | JALANDHAR

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

Significance of Good Friday

Good Friday is a significant day for Christians across the world, as it commemorates the crucifixion and death of Jesus Christ.

It is observed as a day of solemn reflection, prayer, and fasting, remembering the sacrifice Jesus made for the redemption of humanity. Churches hold special services on this day, which include prayer meetings, scripture readings, and sermons focused on sacrifice, humility, and forgiveness. Many Christians attend these services, participate in processions, and engage in charitable acts to help the poor and needy. Some churches also conduct the "Stations of the Cross," which symbolically reenacts Jesus Christ's journey to Calvary.

Devotees take part in prayers, fasting, and meditation, reflecting on themes of sacrifice, suffering, love, and forgiveness. Many Christians fast or abstain from meat on Good Friday as a mark of respect and devotion. Good Friday is a public holiday in India, and government offices, banks, and schools remain closed. For many believers, it is not only a day of mourning but also a day of service, compassion, and faith. It is a day that reminds humanity of love, sacrifice, and forgiveness.

GUNDU K GEORGE | MUMBAI

Dabbawallas suspend services temporarily

Mumbai's iconic dabbawallas have suspended their services for six days, bringing a rare pause to one of the city's most reliable and efficient delivery systems. The suspension is part of their annual tradition, during which many dabbawallas travel to their native places to participate in religious activities, pilgrimages, and community gatherings.

The Mumbai dabbawalla network is considered one of the city's lifelines, delivering home-cooked meals to offices and workplaces across Mumbai with remarkable efficiency. Every day, over 5,000 dabbawallas deliver nearly two lakh tiffin boxes to customers across the city, who depend on their timely and reliable service. The image of a dabbawalla carrying tiffin boxes on Mumbai's local trains has become an iconic symbol of the city's hardworking spirit and efficient transport system. During this six-day break, many customers will have to make alternative food arrangements. The Mumbai suburban railway system continues to support millions of commuters daily, and efforts are being made to improve infrastructure, safety, and passenger convenience. The brief pause highlights the dedication and cultural traditions of Mumbai's iconic dabbawallas.

JAYANTHY SUBRAMANIAM | MUMBAI

America Iran war needs peace

The United States of America is making one radical decision after another regarding the ongoing conflict involving Iran. It is unfortunate that American President Donald Trump has made public statements suggesting that he would finish Iran's task in two to three weeks. Some media reports also highlighted that the US President claimed that Iran's new leadership had personally approached him for a ceasefire. Such statements only make the situation more sensitive and complicated.

In his media interviews, he reportedly said that Iran had gone back 15-20 years and did not have sufficient military strength, resources, air force, or finances to continue the war.

However, recent developments suggest otherwise, as Iran reportedly targeted a data centre facility linked to an American company in Bahrain, indicating that the conflict is far from over.

War only makes peace efforts more difficult and increases global instability. If genuine peace and ceasefire are the goals, then immediate diplomatic dialogue is necessary. Bowing for peace does not make any nation weak; instead, it shows wisdom and responsibility.

KIRTI WADHAWAN | KANPUR

The Strait of Hormuz and the power of strategic imagination

As nations compete for influence over vital maritime routes, the line between simulation and strategy blurs, revealing a deeper truth: that foresight, whether born in code, policy papers, or bold imagination, often precedes the actions that shape the world



NILANTHA
ILANGAMUWA

The focal point: the Straits of Hormuz in the Persian Gulf. Enemy forces have captured seven key military bases, cutting off the major oil supplies of the free world. Your challenge is how you are going to respond. You fly a McDonnell Douglas VTOL BA Harrier, and your mission is to destroy all seven bases without losing your carrier. Your opposition consists of MiG-21 fighters. That was 37 years ago. Have you heard anything about this? I doubt it.

That was Operation Hormuz. This was ten years after the Iranian Revolution, which overthrew a pro-American autocrat and replaced him with a theocrat. It was the final year of the decade-long Soviet intervention in Afghanistan, an intervention whose consequences still haunt the region and its people. From a moral perspective, Americans were not alone in the catalogue of sinners; throughout human history, those who wielded unchecked and unaccountable power inflicted the deepest wounds. Sin and virtue are abstractions; the only measure is the consequences of action or inaction. Returning to Hormuz, the area has changed in shape and form, but the stakes remain as high as ever.

Operation Hormuz was not real; it was virtual, a product of the emerging computer era where games were designed to simulate scenarios of extreme pressure. Introduced in 1989 by Durell Software Ltd., a small British company known for arcade-style and action games, the game was later released in North America as Harrier 7. The company was founded by Robert James Durell White, a self-taught programmer and entrepreneur. Despite the military realism in the game, White had no verified links to any intelligence service or government agency. Yet, decades later, what he simulated eerily reflects the real-world tension and military posturing that now dominate the discussion of the maritime chokepoint, the Strait of Hormuz. The game is a reminder that human imagination often anticipates events long before official institutions respond to them.

Reading materials for this column, I was struck by the audacity of those who envision possibilities that others cannot conceive. People like White, or the scientists submitting classified



HISTORY SHOWS THESE CHOKEPOINTS ARE NEITHER NEW NOR NEUTRAL. SRI LANKA, DESCRIBED IN THE PERIPLUS OF THE ERYTHRAEAN SEA, ACTED AS A MANDATORY STOPOVER FOR ANCIENT TRADERS. GOODS WERE EXCHANGED, REPACKAGED, AND DELIBERATELY MISATTRIBUTED, OBSCURING SUPPLY CHAINS FROM RIVALS

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 The Pioneer

studies decades earlier, approached problems from perspectives that challenge conventional thinking. Today, the Strait of Hormuz is part of everyday conversation. Open source intelligence and global connectivity allow almost anyone to understand its strategic importance within minutes, yet those who first acted, studied, or speculated when the world was ignorant shaped the contours of global policy. The game, Operation Hormuz, is only one illustration of foresight in miniature, a digital simulation of what decades later became a reality in geopolitics. However, it would not be surprising if President Donald Trump only became aware of the Strait of Hormuz days after his fresh interventions in Iran. He might have turned to his inner circle and asked, "Where the hell was that? What is this Hormuz?" Such details may eventually emerge through accounts from those directly involved in high-level decision-making. Time and again, Americans have revealed the messy reality behind closed-door discussions - humour, arrogance, ignorance, and ruthless strategic calculation all intertwined. Had he not been impeached or sidelined, Trump would have continued to steer the West for several years, navigating a path fraught with challenges for himself, his allies, and his adversaries. Yet U.S. military and policymakers - what outsiders often label the "deep state" - have long understood Hormuz and

its lethal significance: the chokepoint's power to control trade, dictate energy security, and determine who holds the lifeblood of the global economy. The nuclear proposal by Howard David Maccabee, submitted in 1963 to G. H. Higgins at the Lawrence Radiation Laboratory, is another piece of evidence of extreme strategic imagination. The report considered the use of nuclear explosives to create a sea-level canal across Israel's Negev Desert, linking the Mediterranean with the Gulf of Aqaba. This was not mere theorising; the report provided technical calculations, including the detonation of multi-kiloton nuclear devices buried up to 1,300 feet deep, spaced four per mile, to remove millions of cubic feet of rock. The proposal was technically feasible but politically incendiary, ethically questionable, and environmentally catastrophic. It assumed the willing use of nuclear detonations in proximity to human settlements, long-term contamination, and the creation of a strategic chokepoint capable of altering global trade. The report estimated costs at roughly two million dollars per mile, yet acknowledged that political and regional opposition would be overwhelming. Its very existence challenges the boundaries between civil engineering and militarisation, showing how far planners were willing to

push the limits of conventional morality in pursuit of strategic advantage. What is vital is that the maritime chokepoints define dominance. The global reaction to China's control of Hambantota illustrates this clearly. The port, leased for ninety-nine years, triggered alarm in Western capitals precisely because it allows Beijing permanent influence over a critical Indian Ocean node. Djibouti, the site of China's first overseas naval base, drew similar consternation, reflecting the stark reality that maritime infrastructure is not commercial alone but a strategic lever.

These moves are rarely discussed in isolation; they form part of a deliberate sequence of manoeuvres where recognition, access, and influence are traded, bought, or forcibly projected. Israel's formal recognition of Somaliland is another chess piece in this grand game, confirming that weak nations and disputed territories become significant when they occupy strategic positions along vital sea routes. The world's powers manoeuvre in these waters, not merely for trade, but for the capacity to coerce, defend, and dominate entire regions. History shows these chokepoints are neither new nor neutral. Sri Lanka, described in the Periplus of the Erythraean Sea, acted as a mandatory stopover for ancient traders. Goods were exchanged, repackaged, and

deliberately misattributed, obscuring supply chains from rivals. The practice of leveraging geography for control has persisted through centuries, from colonial ambitions to modern port leases. Every attempt by a power to control a port or naval base, whether Hambantota or Djibouti, is a continuation of a struggle that has defined empires and nations alike. For the West, each Chinese foothold provokes unease not because of an immediate threat, but because strategic patience, foresight, and denial of advantage have always been markers of decline or resilience. Chokepoints are leverage; they are insurance against irrelevance.

The common obstacle to effective nation-building is not technology, markets, or ideology. It is the absence of a shared sense of responsibility, a coherent national consciousness that aligns citizen priorities with state strategy. Developing such awareness is neither immediate nor simple; it is a process that unfolds over decades, requiring institutions that teach, challenge, and shape perception. Without it, states become reactive rather than proactive, responding to crises rather than anticipating them.

The real question is whether leaders, militaries, and civilians today can match the imagination and audacity of those who came before. Nations build infrastructure, alliances, and military capacity around it. Every discussion, plan, and contingency is informed by the lessons of the past, by simulations, and by exercises that predate the events they now describe. It demonstrates the unbroken chain between theory and action, between imagination and geopolitics, between a self-taught programmer in England and global energy markets. If the world's leaders understood only half the significance of these chokepoints, chaos would dominate trade, energy, and conflict resolution. Yet knowledge alone is insufficient. It must be paired with moral courage, strategic patience, and a willingness to confront consequences without pretence. Historical examples abound where visionaries anticipated problems decades before institutions recognised them. Those who ignore history, technical possibility, and the reality of strategic geography do so at their peril.

The powerful do not negotiate from weakness; they calculate, position, and strike. Those unable to grasp the stakes of chokepoints, whether maritime or political, will inevitably be forced to beg, adapt, or perish. This is the game: timeless, brutal, and unforgiving.

How the long shadow of 'Operation Epic Fury' is shaping India's strategic autonomy



SHANTESH
KUMAR
SINGH

The 2026 U.S.-Israel "Operation Epic Fury" that ended with the death of Iran's Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei in Tehran has shifted the regional landscape in the Middle East in ways few predicted even a year ago. It has forced India to navigate an unprecedented era of volatility.

What started as the horrific Hamas attack on southern Israel in October 2023, claiming roughly 1,200 lives and taking hundreds hostage, quickly proliferated. Hezbollah opened a second front from Lebanon on 8 October, Iran-backed militias launched missiles and drones from Syria and Iraq, and Yemen's Houthis turned the Red Sea into a shooting gallery by striking Red Sea shipping from November 2023 onward.

The March 2024 Houthi missile strike that killed three crew members on a cargo ship forced the Indian Navy into an emergency evacuation of all 20 Indian sailors aboard. It was the moment that brought the crisis straight into Indian landscape.

By late 2025, the conflict had transformed into open Israel-Iran warfare. Early 2026 saw American and Israeli jets pounding Iranian targets. Tehran hit back with ballistic missiles aimed at Israel and Gulf capitals. The region is now juggling multiple simultaneous crises, and India, despite being geographically distant, find itself uncomfortably close to the fallout.

For India, the ongoing crisis is not a distant geopolitical development but a matter of direct strategic consequence and it is a stark reminder that strategic calculations in geopolitics is shaped by realism. New Delhi's response has been characteristically measured yet firm, a principled display of its long-standing diplomatic doctrine of strategic autonomy and balanced engagement. Prime Minister Narendra Modi publicly affirmed Israel's "right to self-defence" and told the Israeli Knesset in February 2026 that India shares its "zero tolerance" principle for terrorism.

At the same time, India has repeatedly called for de-escalation, unimpeded humanitarian corridors in Gaza, and respect for every country's sovereignty. Modi also backed the U.S.-proposed Gaza ceasefire, describing it as a possible path to peace for all people in the

region. These Middle East conflicts have several explicit implications for India's interests. Energy security remains the most immediate concern. India still imports about 85 per cent of its crude oil, largely from the Gulf.

Every spike in oil prices hits the current account deficit, which is 1.2 per cent of its GDP, roughly by 50 basis points wider for every \$10 rise per barrel, consequently putting fresh pressure on the value of the rupee. Strategic petroleum reserves and diversified suppliers such as Russia, the U.S., and African producers have helped New Delhi cushion the blow so far. However, prolonged Strait of Hormuz disruption could still pose a risk. Fertiliser prices that are already volatile would climb sharply if shipping through the Gulf is blocked. It will push the subsidy bill further and squeeze farmers at a time when rural distress remains politically sensitive.

Maritime security has moved from a background concern to a front-page priority. Red Sea disruptions have forced shipping companies to reroute around Africa, adding 10-14 days and thousands of dollars per voyage.

The India-Middle East-Europe Economic Corridor (IMEC), once promoted as India's answer to China's Belt and Road, now looks vulnerable. With the regional transit route destabilized, New Delhi may be forced to re-evaluate its reliance on land-bridges through the Levant. Policy makers in New Delhi are dusting off plans for the International North-South Transport Corridor (INSTC) again. Even though Iran's internal instability makes that route uncertain.

The diaspora and economic dimension is equally pressing. More than nine million Indians live and work across the Gulf. Remittances from the region make up nearly 38 per cent of India's total inward flows, with the UAE alone accounting for almost half of that. When Israel, Qatar, Iran, Iraq and several Gulf states closed their airspace in rapid succession, hundreds of thousands of Indian travellers were stranded. Dubai, Abu Dhabi and Doha, three of the world's busiest aviation hubs, halted air operations that connect Europe, Africa and West Asia.

This showcases the connectivity disruption around the globe. The Indian Embassy in the UAE issued urgent advisories about avoiding unnecessary travel, remaining vigilant and following safety guidelines. New Delhi also arranged special flights. Any prolonged instability threatens not just remittances but also the crucial three pillars of India- and Gulf ties, that is, money, mobility and aviation connectivity.

This current development in global politics could also have ripple effects domestically in India. The Union Home Ministry has sent cir-

culars to all states asking them to monitor pro-Iran radical preachers and inflammatory sermons that could spark communal tension. Protests and mourning gatherings after Khamenei's death were closely watched.

The power vacuum in Tehran adds another layer of complexity. India has contributed considerable resources to the Chabahar Port project. It's a strategic gateway to Afghanistan and Central Asia that neatly bypasses Pakistan. With Iran's leadership in flux and sanctions possibly tightening, protecting those investments while keeping the port operational has become a crucial diplomatic priority. At the same time, India's deepening defence partnership with Israel (drones, missiles, intelligence sharing) is under fresh scrutiny. Any perception of "choosing sides" could complicate relations with the Gulf monarchies that have themselves normalised ties with Israel under the Abraham Accords.

Looking beyond the immediate crisis, the turbulence carries longer-term lessons. It has accelerated internal conversations in India about reducing oil dependence from faster renewable capacity addition to serious exploration of green hydrogen corridors with Gulf partners. It has also reminded policymakers that diversified supply chains are not optional extras but national security imperatives. And it has strengthened the case for greater Indian naval presence in the western Indian Ocean, a trend already visible in the growing frequency of joint patrols and anti-piracy missions.

In the end, the 2026 West Asian crisis is not peripheral for India; it sits at the intersection of energy, trade, diaspora welfare, domestic harmony and great-power balancing. New Delhi's calibrated diplomacy of condemning terrorism without burning bridges, safeguarding sea lanes without over-committing militarily, and diversifying energy sources without abandoning old partners shows both the resilience and the limits of strategic autonomy in an era of cascading crises.

As the dust in Tehran settles (or doesn't), India's task remains the same to keep the oil flowing, protect its people abroad, prevent regional fires from reaching its shores, and stay useful to all sides in any eventual peace process. India needs to have balanced engagement with all stakeholders while contributing constructively to long-term stability in West Asia.

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SHANTI to power India's nuclear energy mission



K P
MOHANAN

Rarely has a piece of legislation in India received such immediate policy backing and long-term strategic alignment as the SHANTI Act, 2025. The Act was passed by the Indian Parliament on December 18 and received presidential assent on December 20. The Union Budget 2026-27, presented on February 1, reflects this long-term policy direction. India's Nuclear Energy Mission, announced in 2025, reflects the country's solemn commitment to clean and sustainable energy for economic growth, aiming to attain the goal of net-zero carbon emissions by 2070. With the SHANTI Act and long-term policy vision, India is positioned to play a larger role in the global nuclear power sector. India's integrated approach aligns with the emerging convergence between AI and nuclear energy. The SHANTI Act 2025 modernises India's civil nuclear legal framework. The Act repeals and replaces the Atomic Energy Act 1962 and the Civil Liability for Nuclear Damage Act 2010. It enables limited private participation in the nuclear sector under regulatory oversight. It strengthens the regulatory environment by granting statutory recognition to the Atomic Energy Regulatory Board (AERB). The Act supports India's clean energy transition and the long-term objective of achieving 100 GW nuclear energy capacity by 2047, which stands at 8.8 GW as of now. The Act aims to build a more advanced and resilient nuclear ecosystem through an integrated framework. The legislation paves the way for modernising the nuclear energy sector, significantly by opening the sector to regulated private and foreign participation. The Act contains a well-charted-out framework for enhanced security, safeguards and emergency preparedness.

The Act allows regulated private participation in plant operations, power generation and equipment manufacturing, including selected fuel-cycle activities such as nuclear fuel fabrication and the enrichment of Uranium-235 up to prescribed limits. All radiation-related activities require prior safety authorisation from the regulator. The Act reserves certain sensitive nuclear fuel-cycle activities for the Central Government or its wholly-owned institutions. It provides a regulatory framework for the use of nuclear and radiation technologies in health care, agriculture, industry, research and other peaceful applications. The Act allows exemption from license for limited activities such as research, development and innovation - related work. The

legislation enables India to scale from 8GW of nuclear capacity to 100 GW by 2047. Analysts estimate investment requirements of over \$200 billion. As global energy demand rises, the SHANTI Act aims to ensure a solid, carbon-free power source. The legislation integrates licensing, regulation, liability and dispute resolution into a well-structured statute. The Act permits foreign participation in stipulated segments of the nuclear energy sector, but only in the capacity of joint venture partners or goods and service providers of establishments in India's private sector. At the same time the ongoing bilateral cooperation and strategic and technological collaboration will be strengthened extensively in the light of liberalised norms in the SHANTI Act.

The country's 2010 Liability Law had deterred global suppliers. The SHANTI Act removes the unlimited liability risk, aligning India with global conventions and making the sector more accessible to experienced global nuclear technology providers, including partners such as Rosatom.

One of the highlights of Budget 2026-27 is the extension of customs duty exemptions for nuclear project goods until 2035. The budgetary initiatives will help the industry stakeholders to have a long-term view and to plan their business streams accordingly. Nuclear power, which currently contributes about three per cent of India's electricity, is set to expand substantially as the country scales capacity toward its 100 GW target by 2047. Kudankulam Nuclear Power Plant (KKNPP) near Kanyakumari, built and operated by NPCIL with Russian technical cooperation (Rosatom), plays a significant role in the country's energy landscape. With Units 1 and 2 operational and Units 3 to 6 under construction, KKNPP is India's largest nuclear facility and a key project within India's nuclear expansion programme. The priority accorded to Small Modular Reactors (SMRs), backed by the Rs. 20,000 crore Nuclear Energy Mission announced in Budget 2025-26, is expected to further strengthen Indo-Russian collaboration in the nuclear energy sector, where Russia has established technological capabilities. President Vladimir Putin's recent visit to India has reaffirmed the importance of bilateral civil nuclear cooperation. Ongoing partnership and the potential deployment of more advanced Russian-designed reactors reinforce a long-term strategic partnership in the nuclear energy domain. The SHANTI Act of 2025 is a landmark legislation which will attract significant investments in India's expanding nuclear energy sector. The Act represents a major structural shift in India's nuclear policy.

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OH, RUPEE

It is a tussle between the central bank, regulator, and speculators. It now seems that it will be a fight till the end. Either of the two will need to give up, at least temporarily, until the loser remounts more attacks in the future. On Monday (March 30), despite the curbs by the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) on short positions, the rupee lost ground. As we had predicted, the speculators came out growling as the rupee lost ground.

Yesterday, they were back in their caves with a whimper, as the rupee roared back to strengthen to just above ₹93 to a dollar compared to more than ₹95. At the end of the day, the central bank was in control, even as the banks, the ones caught in the middle like a deer in the rifle-sight, or sheep to the slaughter, faced the prospects of huge losses. These were the unintended consequences of RBI's moves.

Apart from the curbs on short positions, the central bank stopped offshore-onshore arbitrage, prevented repeated speculative hedges, and reduced circular trading and risks. Legitimate hedging, which is crucial for banks and currency players, is allowed if it is genuine, and requires proof. In a way, the RBI beat up the speculators with policy lashes, and the decibel noise reverberated through the currency markets. It was clear that the central bank will not allow the rupee to touch the scary milestone of ₹100 to a dollar, which was predicted by many experts, or allow it to do so over the next few months. The trick is that one needs to defend and support the rupee so that it remains stronger, relatively, if the Iran war and energy crisis ends soon. In such a scenario, the rupee cannot be allowed to be manipulated by greedy speculators, who wish to make a fast and easy buck. Of course, if the war does not end soon, the rupee will reach or breach the ₹100 mark against the dollar, albeit a bit slowly and steadily.

RBI's moves, coincidentally, came after the finance ministry told Parliament that the rupee was fine, "absolutely fine," and it had performed better than the other Asian currencies, and those of emerging economies. The state minister explained that the central bank did not have a support level in mind, and never does, and its job is to ensure that there is no excessive speculation, and currency finds its real level at its own pace. In effect, no one can force the rupee down, or weaken it with might. Might will be dealt with might, money power with policy power. One needs to remember that in the recent past, the RBI intervened in the market with money power, and lost dismally. Some experts claim that the policy measures are aimed to achieve temporary results, and blunt panic and paranoia. The fact remains that the rupee is on a weak wicket, a sticky wicket, in fact, and no batsman, not even the RBI, can withstand even timid bowling attacks.

In the bargain, according to media reports, some of the banking stocks lost up to four per cent and above during yesterday's trading. At some point or the other, each of the banking stocks was in the red, even as the Nifty Bank index lost nearly three per cent, as the tighter RBI rules may imply huge losses for the banks. The index lost more than four per cent this week, and underperformed the broader Nifty. According to a brokerage house, the bulk of the losses will be booked by the foreign banks, whose exposure is 45 per cent to the currency derivative segment, and private banks, whose exposure is 40 per cent. Although the estimates for the overall losses, ₹5,000 crore, are not unusually high, or unmanageable, the panic on the Dalal Street and volatility on the Main Street is due to sentiments. No one knows how far the RBI will go to protect the rupee. No one knows the moneybags with the speculators, who sense a killing on the currency exchange.

Bears growl and cower, stand up to their giant heights, and go on the four legs to escape to their hiding places. The bulls are not charging, as is normally the case. In the form of the regulators and policy shapers, they seem to stand their ground, not budge an inch, and make up for lost ground, or territory, if any, with renewed policy dances and moves. The former, bears, are aggressive, moving with a combination of wildness and tameness. The latter, bulls, are stealthy, quiet, cunning, moving back when pushed, and quietly striding ahead to cover lost ground. The target in the mind of the central bank seems to be ₹93-94 to a dollar, and not let it breach ₹95, from where it can slide to ₹100. The bears want to see ₹100, or maybe ₹110, who knows. In the process, the banking system may go for a six, even if temporarily, as foreign exchange deals, hedging, moving money from one currency to another, are regular features without which a bank cannot survive. They need to operate with both hands tied behind their backs.

The Pioneer

NEW DELHI | FRIDAY | APRIL 3, 2026

BUSINESS

10

A private-fuelled public take-off

State-run airports get a profit push due to private partnerships

In the post-reforms period, the public sector grew, and faltered. In the latter case, across many sectors, the private groups profited from the decline and demise of the state-owned firms. However, there may be a unique case when private revenues bolstered the public profits. Adani Airports, which was recently in the news because of the hype about massive expansion, and forthcoming IPO (Initial Public Offering, and is part of one of the fastest-growing private groups, may have aided and abetted the profitability of the state-owned Airports Authority of India (AAI). Unlike many public sector firms, AAI gained from the former.

According to AAI's 2024-25 annual report, which was released recently, lease revenues from airports, including those managed through public-private partnerships (PPPs), accounted for more than a third of the annual revenues, or a jump of almost 50 per cent over the previous year. The six PPP airports, Ahmedabad, Jaipur, Lucknow, Mangaluru, Guwahati, and Thiruvananthapuram, are operated by Adani Airports, and contributed almost ₹3,200 crore, or more than 15 per cent of the annual revenues. The remaining came from the deals with the two major airports in Delhi and Mumbai, which have legal complications.

Experts contend that in the fast-changing aviation landscape, the state is surely shifting from an operational model to a 'landlord' one, where it earns by leasing the airports and aviation infrastructure. The so-called rental revenues drive the profits too. One of them feels that such revenues contribute almost a third of the profits. This is substantial. The combined revenues from the six PPP airports (₹3,200 crore), and Delhi and Mumbai together (almost ₹4,200 crore under joint venture model), account for nearly 36 per cent of the annual revenues in 2024-25, and add

₹700-odd crore to the profits, according to experts.

As per the annual report, "This (PPP) demonstrates the continued success of our... arrangements, and their positive impact on revenue generation." In the case of Delhi and Mumbai, revenues went up by 4.52 per cent compared to the previous year. But the major jump was in the six PPPs, where the topline growth was more than three times, largely due to what is dubbed as 'under-recovery' or "compensation paid by private operators for investments AAI made before the airports were leased out." The under-recovery contributed more than ₹2,200 crore, and includes one-time payment that will not recur.

This is explained in the annual report's notes to the accounts. The PPP deals note that the "Concessionaire (Adani) shall be liable to pay to AAI an amount equivalent to the investments made by AAI in the Aeronautical Assets... considered by the Regulator as part of the Regulatory Asset Base, subject to requisite reconciliation, true-up, and final determination by the Regulator of the quantum of such investment. The Concessionaire shall also be liable to pay to the AAI an amount equivalent to the estimated depreciated value of investments made by the AAI in Non-Aeronautical Assets... towards development of Non-Aeronautical Assets, i.e., Initial Non-Aeronautical Investments."

In addition, the private party in PPPs pay fees per passenger, which are different for domestic and international travellers, to the AAI. In 2024-25, the domestic passenger fee went up between ₹20 and ₹31, and for international ones the hike ranged between ₹41 and ₹62. The highest fee for domestic passengers was in Ahmedabad, with the lowest in Mangaluru. The situation was the

same in the case of international passengers. The difference between domestic and international in the six airports is the same, double for the latter.

Media reports indicate that the financial fortunes of the AAI seem to be built not just on the growing 'landlord' model, with leases and rentals being the income earners, apart from profits, but on the slippery operations. Without the first, the second is tarnished, as the "bulk of its own network remains under strain. An estimated 91, or about 75 per cent, of the 122 airports owned by AAI reported losses of ₹1,600 crore, while the remaining 31 airports earned a profit of ₹2,740 crore" in 2024-25, according to an analysis in a media report.

Of the profitable airports owned by the AAI, Kolkata generated ₹855 crore, and Chennai ₹500 crore, with Pune, Patna, Srinagar, and Bagdogra being in the black. The ones in the red included those in Rajkot, Vijayawada, and Kushinagar, with the ones in Shimla and Vellore being non-operational. The scenario sketched out may indicate that private rentals, especially from the Adani Group, saved the AAI. This is possibly the way forward as reports indicate that the private partner hopes to invest \$15 billion in airports over the next five years.

The aim is to increase passenger capacity to 200 million annually, with huge upgrades at the five PPP airports, minus Mangaluru, and new terminals, taxiways, and a runway at the Navi Mumbai International Airport. It may participate in the bidding for more airports, 11 of which may be up for grabs in April 2026, according to news reports. Thus, there is a sense of excitement about privatisation, either as PPP or joint venture, despite the legal and policy complications. If Adani bags some of the new airports, it may prove to be a boost for its IPO in 2027-28.

However, if one looks closely at the data, the two of the major revenue earners for the AAI in the private models are Delhi and Mumbai, the two metros that handle the bulk of passengers and freight, both domestic and international. The six PPPs managed by Adani are huge tourist attractions for inbound, outbound, and internal travel. The same is the case with the airports owned by the AAI, with major revenues from Kolkata and Chennai, and other well-travelled destinations. Thus, most of the money comes from thriving airports. The private parties may or may not have much to do, except increase in efficiency, and extra investments, which the AAI was unable to do.

One will need to see what happens in the next round of 11 airports, when the government plans to bundle the seemingly-profitable ones with loss-making ones. Until now, the private sector bagged the profitable assets, or those that were low-lying fruits, whose fortunes were easy to turn around with minimal efforts. If the private sector can show similar results in the bundled airports, it will prove its success. Until then, the issue is open. Blaming AAI, and praising the private sector may result in more profitable airports falling into the latter's clutches.

A Tech Wrecker

Revenge of brick-n-mortar stores

Forget the Iran and online wars; physical retail took off in 2025

Intuitively, most wrote off physical retail, or brick-n-mortar commercial spaces in this age of online commerce. The wars, geopolitics, trade and tariff battles, and volatility enhance the desire to write such obits. Yet, the numbers defy imaginations, and offer a counterintuitive narrative. CBRE stated that the retail real estate market witnessed a record nearly nine million sq ft absorption in 2025, nearly half of it coming in as new supply. More than two million sq ft of new supply was operational in the second half of 2025. JLL stated that gross leasing volume hit 12.5 million sq ft in the top seven cities, the highest in three years.

Physical stores, or malls, where footfalls fell, are back with a vengeance. Indeed, in this hoopla, and rightly so, about e-commerce, physical retail serves multiple functions, which include brand theatre, logistics node, trust engine, data collection point, and margin management tool. The evidence stems beyond the metros, and into the smaller cities. Trent, the Tata Group retailer behind Westside and Zudio, added more than 100 stores in the first three quarters of 2025-26, and took the overall number to more than 1,100. Nearly two-thirds of the new stores came up in new towns, new cities, and peripheral micro-markets.

At the top end of the retail market, the problem is not weak demand but too little space. According to a news agency, India has three true luxury malls, two in New Delhi, and one in Mumbai. DLF, a renowned realtor, feels that there is "zero availability" for new brands, and at least 15 major labels were ready to enter if there is enough space. DLF plans to double the leasable area of luxury-mall, Emporio, from 1,60,000 sq ft, but it will be operational in end-2028. The luxury goods market is estimated at \$12.1 billion, less than three per cent of China's.

Of course, the physical store is not, and cannot, replace or substitute online. The former adds another layer to an omnichannel system. Hence, Reliance Retail, which operates more than 19,000 stores and serves 350 million, hopes to pilot a search-and-discovery platform to integrate physical and online experiences. Shoppers scan QR codes in the stores to get tailored suggestions. The point is not merely digital convenience. It is to use the stores as traffic, fulfilment, and data assets. Physical retail, whose efficacy was judged by sales per sq foot and footfalls, reduces prices, improves conversions, lowers returns, raises attachment rates, enables click-and-collects, and supplies fulfilment.

Across categories such as fashion, electronics, and beauty, physical can reduce the

uncertainties, a factor that online platforms struggle with. Indeed, several segments of e-commerce, especially quick commerce, have grown around physical retail. In effect, brick-n-mortar becomes a hedge against digital fragility. Quick commerce compresses delivery windows but does not always solve the issue of product discovery, fit, advice, or premium presentation. Online channels expand reach, but intensify discounting, and make brands hostage to algorithms and positioning. Physical stores give brands more control over the overall ecosystem, environment, pricing, and customer interaction.

CBRE's chairman and CEO, Anshuman Magazine, noted in early 2025 that leasing momentum is being driven by experiential flagship stores, kiosks, and Gen Z-focused formats. This is not a decorative trend but a response to the limits of digital-selling. The macro backdrop, however, is shifting beneath store expansion. Retail inflation stood at 3.2 per cent in February 2026, but experts expect energy-led pressures to push it higher. For retailers, this feeds into a chain of costs that is rarely visible to consumers, and includes freight, AC, operating expenses, imported merchandises, packaging, fit-outs, and store launches.

Mail supply is tight, premium brands want space, some categories view stores as conversion engines, and large chains have room to expand into smaller towns. In such a scenario, the last six months may look like a strong build-out phase in which retailers used stores because of the rise in digital growth. The fact remains that margins are under a squeeze. Reliance Retail's core margin slipped to eight per cent in the October-December 2025 quarter, down from 8.6 per cent a year earlier, partly because of festive discounting, local-delivery investments, and labour-related impacts. If the Iran war continues, the trend may escalate.

A prolonged shock may create segmentation inside physical retail. Large players with stronger balance sheets, supply-chain depth, and omnichannel capabilities may expand using market stress to lock in locations and negotiate better terms. Smaller brands, especially the digital-first labels that desire

to move offline, can find the store economics harder to sustain if rents, fit-out costs, and working capital needs rise. The possibility is missed in broad "offline comeback" narratives. In essence, the stores may be back but not every retailer can afford a strategic version that the next phase may require.

Question of timing around supplies matters. The high-end retail infrastructure is thin. Even if demand strengthens, new premium mall projects in Mumbai, Hyderabad, and Gurugram will take years. This implies that parts of the physical retail may be constrained by supplies when global brands want more exposure. In a weak external environment, this works both ways. Scarcity protects the best assets, but limits how quickly retailers can monetise demand. The useful way to read the last six months, then, is not as proof that physical retail has defeated digital retail. It is that the store has changed.

Stores are no longer just the physical spots where deals and transactions happen. They are places where the brands defend pricing,

reduce returns, capture intent, localise fulfilment, and create presence in a market where distribution matters. In other words, the benefits are counter to what happens in the online spaces. Whether this turns into a long runway, or a more selective phase of expansion will depend less on ideology about "online versus offline" than on what happens to the economic macro fundamentals over the next few months.

Hence, unlike 2025, when physical retail expanded by leaps and bounds, and possibly complemented online commerce, or the former countered the disadvantages of the latter, this year will not be the same. There are additional pressures to global trade and tariff issues. There is a real possibility of a real global recession. If the Iran war, energy crisis, logistics problems, fall of currencies, trade disruptions, and manufacturing upsets chip off a couple of percentage points from potential growths among emerging economies, and flake off a few basic points from major economies, retail will be in trouble. So will real estate and, of course, the future of the commercial malls.

The Pioneer

SINCE 1865

Stock markets stage stunning comeback, rupee rebounds

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

Staging a spirited recovery, stock markets pared early losses to close higher on Thursday, with the benchmark Sensex rising by 185 points and the broader Nifty settling above 22,700 on strong value buying in IT and banking shares and a sharp rebound in the rupee.

Rebounding more than 2,000 points from the day's low, the 30-share BSE Sensex finally settled higher by 185.23 points, or 0.25 per cent, at 73,319.55. The index opened lower and tanked further by 1,588 points to hit a day's low of 71,545.81 in the first half of the session. Strong value buying in IT bellwethers like HCL Tech and TCS, and banking giants HDFC Bank and ICICI Bank, helped the barometer

recover from sharp losses, hitting a high of 73,568.54 in the pre-close session.

The 50-share NSE Nifty followed a similar trajectory and closed above 22,700 at 22,713.10, up by 33.70 points, or 0.15 per cent. The index fell 496.85 points, or 2.19 per cent, in early trade before recovering to hit a high of 22,782.30.

A sharp rebound in the rupee after the Reserve Bank stepped in with a slew of measures to restrict banks from onshore forward markets also helped improve investor sentiment. The rupee rebounded by 188 paise to hit the 92 level against the US dollar briefly in the day trade before settling over 150 paise higher.

Bargain hunting in IT stocks supported the recovery, with HCL Technologies and Tech Mahindra ending nearly 3 per

cent higher. Infosys, Tata Consultancy Services, HDFC Bank, Bajaj Finance, Maruti Suzuki India, Titan, Axis Bank, Bharat Electronics Ltd, Kotak Mahindra Bank and ITC were the major gainers among Sensex shares.

On the other hand, Asian Paints, Eternal, Sun Pharmaceuticals, NTPC, Reliance Industries, PowerGrid, Mahindra & Mahindra, UltraTech Cement, Adani Ports, Bajaj Finserv and Tata Steel were the only laggards.

"Indian equity markets opened on the back foot as Trump's renewed threat to strike Iran 'extremely hard' swiftly erased the optimism built in the prior session, triggering broad-based selling across Asian markets," Vinod Nair, Head of Research, Geojit Investments Ltd, said.



Rupee strengthens, settles at 93.14 against USD after RBI measures

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Mumbai

The rupee logged one of its steepest single-day gains in many years and settled 156 paise higher at 93.14 (provisional) against the US dollar on Thursday after the Reserve Bank stepped in with a slew of measures to restrict banks from onshore forward markets.

The domestic unit, however, remained under pressure due to the unabated withdrawal of foreign capital, a strengthening dollar, and rising crude oil prices amid a volatile geopolitical situation, forex analysts said. At the inter-bank foreign exchange, the rupee opened at 94.62 and registered a sharp single-day surge of 188 paise to touch an intra-day high of 92.82 against the greenback.

At the end of the session, the rupee was quoted at 93.14 (provisional) against the dollar, higher by 156 paise, or 1.6 per cent,



from its previous closing level. The local currency breached the 95-level on Monday before closing at 94.70 versus the greenback. It had settled at a historic low of 94.84 against the dollar on Friday, prompting the RBI to intervene with multiple measures.

India's manufacturing sector growth slips to 4-yr low

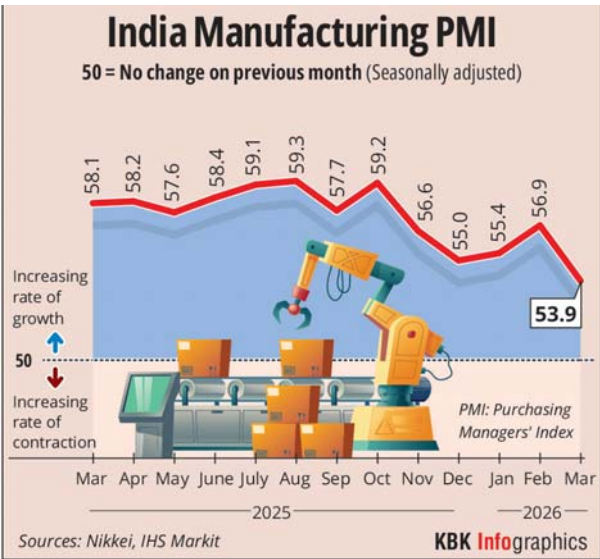
PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

India's manufacturing sector growth eased to a four-year low in March as cost pressures, fierce competition, heightened market uncertainty and the war in the Middle East led to softer increases in new orders and output, a monthly report said on Thursday.

The seasonally adjusted HSBC India Manufacturing Purchasing Managers' Index (PMI) fell from 56.9 in February to 53.9 in March, indicating the weakest improvement in overall business conditions in close to four years.

In the PMI parlance, a print above 50 means expansion, while a score below 50 denotes contraction.

"India's manufacturing PMI eased to 53.9 in March from 56.9 in February, marking its



lowest level since June 2022. Disruptions linked to the conflict in the Middle East are reverberating through the global economy and weighing on Indian manufacturers,"

said Pranjul Bhandari, Chief India Economist at HSBC. The two largest sub-components of the PMI, new orders and output, rose at the slowest rates since mid-2022,

the survey said, adding that growth was curbed by challenging market conditions, cost pressures and the war in the Middle East.

"Output and new orders slowed noticeably, signalling softer demand and greater uncertainty. Meanwhile, input costs rose sharply across a broad range of items, including aluminium, chemicals and fuels. For now, firms appear to be absorbing much of the increase, keeping output prices relatively contained," Bhandari said.

Firms faced an intensification of cost pressures, the steepest since August 2022. But, there was a slower increase in output charges. The rate of output price inflation receded to a two-year low, curbed by customer-retention efforts and attempts to secure new clients at some firms, the survey said.

India's defence exports rise 62 pc to hit record ₹38,424 crore in FY26

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

India's annual defence exports touched an all-time high of ₹38,424 crore in the financial year 2025-26, marking more than 62 per cent growth over the previous fiscal year, Defence Minister Rajnath Singh said on Thursday.

The "big jump" in the defence exports reflected the growing "global trust" in India's indigenous defence capabilities, Singh said in a social media post, adding that the country is "scripting an impressive defence exports success story". "India defence exports have touched a new all-time high with a record ₹38,424 crore in FY 2025-26. It marks a robust 62.66 per cent growth over the previous fiscal," the Defence Minister said.

"This big jump of ₹14,802 crore in defence exports reflects the growing global trust in India's indigenous capabilities and advanced manufacturing strength," he said. With DPSUs (defence public sector undertakings)



contributing 54.84 per cent and private industry 45.16 per cent, this milestone showcases the power of a collaborative and self-reliant defence ecosystem, he said.

India's defence exports in 2024-25 was ₹23,622 crore in 2024-25. It was ₹21,083 crore in 2023-24. The Defence Ministry described defence exports in 2025-26 as a "landmark milestone".

"This accomplishment of the Indian

defence industry is in line with the Prime Minister Narendra Modi's vision to position India among the world's top defence exporters," it said.

"In terms of value of contribution, the private sector accounted for ₹17,353 crore worth of defence exports, while DPSUs contributed ₹21,071 crore. Their respective figures in the previous financial year stood at ₹15,233 crore and ₹8,389 crore," it said.

Govt exempts import duty on key petrochemical products

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The government on Thursday exempted import of critical petrochemical products from customs duty for three months till June 30, to ensure supply stability and provide relief to consumers of final products amid the crisis in West Asia.

Sectors dependent on petrochemical feedstock and intermediates such as plastics, packaging, textiles, pharmaceuticals, chemicals, automotive components and other manufacturing segments will benefit from the duty exemption which will cost the exchequer ₹1,800 crore.

In a statement, the finance ministry said in light of the ongoing conflict in West Asia and the consequent disruptions in global supply chains,



the government has decided to provide full customs duty exemption on critical petrochemical products till June 30.

"This measure has been taken as a temporary and targeted relief in order to ensure continued availability of critical petrochemical inputs for domestic industry, reduce cost pressures on downstream sectors, and safeguard supply stability in the country," it said.

This will also provide relief to consumers of final products, it added.

The goods on which the customs duty have been exempted include Methanol, Anhydrous ammonia, Toluene, Styrene, Dichloromethane (methylene chloride), Vinyl chloride monomer, Poly butadiene, Styrene butadiene and Unsaturated polyester resins.

Scindia sets deadline for India Post to adopt DoT's pension portal

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Minister of Communications Jyotiraditya Scindia on Thursday issued a one-week deadline to the Department of Posts for integrating its pension services with the telecom department's 'SAMPANN' portal.

Speaking at an event in the national capital, Scindia directed top officials from both departments to end ongoing discussions and finalise the integration immediately.

"Why is it that the postal department is not using the Sampann portal? I want (officials) to meet straight after this function," Scindia said.

Noting that internal discussions have been dragging on, he added, "Talks have a



way of going on forever. So, by the end of next week, I want this matter settled."

The minister made these remarks during an event marking the 75th anniversary of the Postal Training Centre (PTC) in Saharanpur, where he also released a commemorative postage stamp to celebrate the institution's platinum jubilee.

Govt exceeds FY26 indirect tax collection estimates

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The government has marginally exceeded the indirect tax collection target for fiscal 2025-26, an official said on Thursday.

The total indirect tax collection, which includes customs, excise and GST, as per Revised Estimates (RE) was pegged at over ₹15.52 lakh crore for FY26. This includes ₹2.58 lakh crore from customs duty, ₹3.38 lakh crore from excise duty, and ₹9.58 lakh crore from Central Goods and Services Tax (CGST).

Without giving actual figures, the official said that revenues from customs duty came in at 102 per cent of RE, while in case of excise duty it was 101 per cent of RE. The Central GST collection came in at 100.8 per cent of RE for



FY26. "Overall, GST plus non-GST collection came in at 101.2 per cent of RE," the official said.

However, the collection from health and national security cess, which is levied on pan masala manufacturing has missed the target.

The RE had pegged ₹2,330 crore from the health and national security cess collection in FY26. However, the actual collections for FY26 came in lower at 63 per cent of RE.

The RE had pegged collections from the health and national security cess at ₹2,330 crore for FY26. However, actual collections fell short, reaching only 63 per cent of the RE.

Under the Health and National Security Cess Act, a cess is levied on the manufacturing capacity of pan masala units effective February 1, 2026. The cess is levied over and above the highest 40 per cent GST rate.

Gold futures drops nearly 4 pc to ₹1.47 lakh/10g

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

Gold prices plunged ₹6,004 to ₹1.47 lakh per 10 grams in futures trade on Thursday amid intensified geopolitical tensions in West Asia that boosted the US dollar and dampened the investors' sentiment.

Snapping a four-day winning streak, the yellow metal for the June delivery plunged ₹6,004, or 3.91 per cent, to ₹1,47,704 per 10 grams on the Multi Commodity Exchange.

Analysts said precious metal prices declined as the US dollar rebounded following remarks by President Donald Trump indicating a potential escalation in the ongoing conflict with Iran.

Gold prices declined on Thursday, ending a four-day gain, as the US dollar rebounded after President Donald Trump warned that the military campaign in Iran could continue with more intense action over the next two to three weeks, Jigar Trivedi, Senior Research Analyst at IndusInd Securities, said.

In the international markets, Comex gold futures for the June contract also ended a four-day rally, depreciating \$194.70, or 4.05 per cent, to \$4,618.40 per ounce.

In an address from the White House, President Donald Trump said Washington's core strategic objectives in Iran were nearing completion. However, he added that the US would hit Iran "extremely hard" for the next two to three weeks.

Meanwhile, Trump offered no timeline to the end of the war on Iran and no solution to the closure of the Strait of Hormuz that



has crippled global financial markets.

Jigar Trivedi said this stance by the US President had strengthened the US dollar, adding that the greenback has recently emerged as a safe-haven asset, putting pressure on dollar-denominated precious metals. Crude oil prices also resumed their advance, reinforcing inflation concerns and expectations of tighter monetary policy.

"Traders have fully priced out the prospect of interest rate cuts in 2026 by the US Federal Reserve, a stark reversal from pre-war expectations of two cuts," Trivedi said.

VinFast to introduce VF MPV7 in India

KUSHAN MITRA ■ Hanoi

VinFast the automotive arm of Vietnam's largest conglomerate Vin Group announced that they are going to launch their third product for the Indian market, the seven-seat VF MPV7 in India. Pre-bookings for the electric seven seat multi-person vehicle have opened and can be made for ₹21,000 and the vehicle will be officially launched on April 15.

VinFast launched operations in India last year with the VF6 and VF7 electric SUVs last year and the Vietnamese brand has tasted success already. In March 2026, they registered 691 vehicles in India accord to VAHAN data which excludes Telangana.

The VF MPV7 will also be sold in a commercial variant called 'Limogreen' for the taxi segment. Sales will start concurrently and this product will also be used by VinFast to begin their own electric vehicle taxi operation 'GSM' later this year.

Speaking to the media, Tapan Ghosh, CEO, VinFast India said that the company's success in India will continue with the MPV7. "We have



learned that Indian consumers want 'Peace of Mind' when they purchase an electric vehicle and thus we are offering a ten-year battery warranty on our vehicles and free charging at our sister company VGreen charging stations until March 2029. We have also tied up with Hindustan Petroleum for

charging stations."

To address the fear of high depreciation of electric vehicles, Ghosh added that VinFast was offering industry leading levels of resale value. "We are offering assured residual value of 75 percent after two years and 55 percent after five years", he said while addressing the

media. The company which has committed to a \$500 million investment for a new manufacturing facility in Tamil Nadu's Toothikudi is going to enhance their offerings going forward as well, as well as their sales and service network. "Our sales network for four wheelers will expand to 75 outlets by the end of the

year", Ghosh said while adding that VinFast will explore launching more products such as the micro-car VF3 and the luxury SUV VF9 in the coming months.

However Ghosh did confirm that VinFast will bring their two-wheeler business to India in the coming months and is also exploring opportunities in the electric bus business with new urban bus contracts coming soon.

VinFast which was founded in 2017 has rapidly become the largest carmaker in Vietnam, with a 36 percent market share and delivered 175,000 cars in the country in 2025 overtaking the likes of Toyota and Hyundai.

They have also rapidly expanded operations across Asia with sales growth in Indonesia and the Philippines, but had to scale back ambitions in the US market like many other global carmakers due to American consumers not wanting to go down the electric route. VinFast sees a major growth opportunity in India with the government aiming for 30 percent of car sales becoming electric vehicles by 2030.

FROM THE WORLD

US

Sanctions lifted on Rodriguez

The US on Wednesday lifted sanctions on Venezuela's acting President Delcy Rodriguez, according to an Office of Foreign Assets Control entry on the Treasury Department website. The newly-announced sanctions relief represents a strong signal that the US recognises Rodriguez as a legitimate authority in Venezuela. Washington has already formally recognised her as the country's head of state in legal and diplomatic settings. The lifted sanctions come as the Trump administration has been engaging with Venezuela's interim government since the US military captured Rodriguez's predecessor, Nicolas Maduro, and his wife on January 3 in Venezuela's capital, Caracas.

US-Europe rift widens as Trump lashes out at NATO allies

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ London

US President Donald Trump says he's strongly considering pulling the United States out of NATO, ratcheting up his criticism of European leaders and exposing a wider rift in the trans-Atlantic alliance — this time over the Iran war.

While Trump's talk of a possible NATO pullout dates back years, the comments to The Telegraph newspaper in the UK, published Wednesday, were among the clearest and most disparaging yet — suggesting that the fracture has deepened perhaps to a point of no return.

Asked whether he would reconsider US membership in the alliance after the conflict in the Middle East ends, Trump replied, "I would say (it's) beyond reconsidera-

tion." Congress passed legislation in 2023 that would prevent any president from pulling out of NATO without its approval. The Trump administration, during his first term, had insisted the president had such authority on his own.

It's unclear whether Trump would challenge in any way the new law, which is the first of its kind and with the NATO provision specifically championed at the time by Trump's secretary of state, Marco Rubio, who was a Florida senator at the time.

There are efforts under way to reinforce America's relationship with NATO, with its secretary-general, Mark Rutte, scheduled to visit Washington next week. The visit by Rutte was confirmed by a White House official who was not authorised to



comment on the yet to be formally announced visit and spoke on the condition of anonymity.

UK Prime Minister Keir Starmer said his government was "fully committed to NATO" and called it "the single most effective military alliance the world has ever seen."

Before a Trump speech

later Wednesday, US Sen Mitch McConnell, a Kentucky Republican, and Sen Chris Coons, a Delaware Democrat, said in a joint statement that "NATO is the most successful military alliance in history" and stressed that the Senate "will continue to support the alliance for the peace and protection it provides" the United States, Europe and the

world. Many European leaders have felt political pressure over the war, which faces opposition in their countries and has sent petroleum prices soaring as Iran has effectively shut the Strait of Hormuz, the narrow waterway between Iran and Oman through which about one-fifth of the world's oil passes.

The UK is working on plans that could help assuage Trump, and Starmer said military planners will work on a postwar security plan for the Strait. On Thursday, British Foreign Secretary Yvette Cooper will host a virtual meeting of 35 countries that have signed up to help ensure security for shipping in the Strait - after the fighting ends.

Julia-Sabina Joja, a senior fellow at the Middle East Institute, alluded to Trump's

exhortation Tuesday for allies to "go get your own oil" in a social media post insisting it wasn't America's job to secure the Strait.

"The Europeans are not keen to go into an active warfare situation, to so-called get' their energy out of the Strait," said Joba, a former deputy project manager at NATO Allied Command Transformation in Virginia.

Time to reexamine the relationship, says Rubio says: As energy prices have spiked, Trump has called NATO allies "cowards" for not sending their military ships to the Strait. It's an amplification of his message since his first term that European partners should assume greater responsibility for their own security.

Speaking Tuesday on Fox News, Rubio said, "I do think,

unfortunately, we are going to have to reexamine whether or not this alliance that has served this country well for a while is still serving that purpose."

Rubio raised questions with interviewer Sean Hannity about whether NATO has "become a one-way street where America is simply in a position to defend Europe - but when we need the help of our allies, they're going to deny us basing rights and they're going to deny us overflight."

The fraying of NATO could weaken the alliance's deterrence, particularly with Russia: It seeks to limit conflict by having Russian President Vladimir Putin believe that NATO would retaliate if he decides to one day expand Moscow's war in Ukraine.

SOUTH CENTRAL RAILWAY
Follow us on @SCRailwayIndia
Details of the Tender Notices of S.C Railway can be seen on our website : www.scr.indianrailways.gov.in

TENDER NOTICE No.38 to 40, DR_M_HYB_26 dt. 31/03/2026

On behalf of the President of India, Divisional Railway Manager/ Works, Hyderabad Division, South Central Railway, Secunderabad invites Open Tenders for the following works through e-procurement up to 15.00 hours of 30/04/2026s.

Tender No.: 38_DRM_W_HYB_26, Name of the work: A. Hyderabad Division:Provision of room for Substation, HT/LT strengthening at Medchal as part of Amrit Bharat Scheme. - B. Improvements to existing station building at AMQ and prov/repairs of toilets at AMQ & DYE. (work to be executed at AMQ & DYE) - C. Hyderabad Division: Provision of lift on Island Platform at LGDH - D. HYB Div:-Safiguda:- Extension of Platform No.2/3 (Island Platform) by 75 meters. - E. HYB Div:-Extension of platform by 100m at Bolarum PF No. 2/3 - , Approx Value (Rs.): 2,77,03,231.00, EMD (Rs.): 5,54,100.00

Tender No.: 39_DRM_W_HYB_26, **Name of the work:** Provision of yard material Stacking room at six station each under SSE/P.Way/ UMRI & NZB B) Hyderabad Division - Sleeper Matting at station and PWI offices C) Hyderabad Division - UMRI - Provision of boundary wall at MUE end (500 Meters) D) Hyderabad Division - Repair to Drain work (800m on both LH and RH side) and Stone pitching at KMC E) Hyderabad Division - UPW - Side drain raising (Stone masonry) for 300m F) Hyderabad Division - Repair to Drain work 800m on either side LH and RH of point 13B at UPW G) Hyderabad Division : Proposed Drain construction at IDL near LC at Km 482/600-900 H) Hyderabad Division - Provision of Grating cum bailing of accumulated water between Good Loop and Loop line-2 I) Hyderabad Division - Provision of toe wall from Km. 458/900-500 for 300m J) Hyderabad Division - Provision of Buffer stops as a part of extension of dead end with concrete sleeper at BDHN and other stations (Non-Track Portion), Approx Value (Rs.): 8,80,66,798.00, EMD (Rs.): 17,61,400.00

Tender No.: 40_DRM_W_HYB_26, **Name of the work:** Construction of TRIP SHED KCG under SSE / Works / KCG jurisdiction, Approx Value (Rs.): 2,80,05,854.00, EMD (Rs.): 5,60,100.00

For further details visit the website www.irops.gov.in

Divisional Railway Manager/ Works/Hyderabad

TENDER NOTICE

On behalf of the President of India, Sr. Divisional Signal & Telecom Engineer, Secunderabad Division, South Central Railway, Secunderabad invites open tenders for the following works through e-procurement of the tenders

Sl. No. 1, Tender No. & Date: C_SG_36_598 Dt:01.04.2026, Closing dt: 22.04.2026, **Name of the work:** Replacement of defective / aged Non RDSO Fire & Smoke detection Alarm system with RDSO type in Relay Room, equipment room and Battery room at 30 no. of station / locations and fire aspiration system in KJZ - SC-WD, VKB - PRLI, KHNP - KUKT, DKJ - MUGR, PSHP - BDCR, MTMI - SSSL section (B & D Routes) over SC Division, Approx. Value (₹): 7,57,33,765.32, Bid security/EMD (₹): 15,14,700.00,

For further details visit the website www.irops.gov.in; Bid security /EMD to be paid as per GCC 2022

*As per IRSGCC-2022, e-Tender Forms shall be issued free of cost to all tenderers. (Ref: IRGCC 2022 part-I, Clause-3)

Sr.Divisional Signal & Telecom Engineer/ A004 Secunderabad

For further tender conditions / details and for downloading the tender documents, Please visit website at <http://www.irops.gov.in> or www.scr.indianrailways.gov.in

China in communication with all parties about Strait of Hormuz

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Beijing

China on Thursday said that it is in communication "with all parties" about the need to restore stability in the Strait of Hormuz and that everyone should work toward that end. "We believe that an early cease-fire and restoration of peace and stability in the Strait of Hormuz and its adjacent waters is a common aspiration of the international community, and all sides should work towards this end," Chinese Foreign Ministry spokesperson Mao Ning said.

"China is maintaining communication and coordination with all parties," she

said. Mao said that "the root cause of the disruption to navigation in the Strait of Hormuz lies in the illegal military actions taken by the US and Israel against Iran," and said the way to restore safety in the area is to end the hostilities.

"Military means cannot fundamentally resolve the

issue, and an escalation of the conflict is not in the interest of any party," she said.

China and Pakistan agreed this week to promote a five-point proposal, which includes calls to start peace talks as soon as possible and to guarantee the safety of navigation

Probe into Zubeen's death concluded: SPF

GURDIP SINGH
■ Singapore

The Singapore Police Force (SPF) has confirmed that investigations into the death of singer Zubeen Garg in Singapore on September 19, 2025, have concluded and there is no evidence of foul play.

In accordance with the Singapore Coroners Act 2010, the SPF investigated the case thoroughly and examined available evidence and recorded statements from all relevant witnesses, a statement issued on Wednesday read.

The statement was issued in response to media queries, said SPF, reminding members of the public to refrain from comments that impugn the integrity of the

court's judgement or the judicial process. SPF's investigation has established that Garg was on a yacht trip in the waters off Lazarus Island. He had initially worn a life jacket while swimming but later removed it and returned to the yacht without the life jacket on

him, the statement said.

When he entered the water the second time, he swam alone and away from the yacht without a life jacket, despite being offered one before entering the water. Subsequently, while swimming back towards the yacht, he was observed to

have become unresponsive. According to the statement, Garg was promptly rescued by the captain of the yacht and members of his group and brought back to the vessel, where cardiopulmonary resuscitation was immediately administered.

A Police Coast Guard boat was dispatched shortly after the emergency call, and officers arrived promptly to render assistance, it said, adding that Garg was attended to by paramedics upon reaching shore and was conveyed promptly by ambulance to Singapore General Hospital, where he subsequently passed away.

Post-mortem findings, including toxicology analysis and autopsy results, were consistent with a case of death by drowning. (PTI)

US court poised to reject Trump's birthright citizenship limits

MARK SHERMAN
■ Washington

The Supreme Court seemed poised Wednesday to reject US President Donald Trump's restrictions on birthright citizenship in a momentous case that was magnified by his unparalleled presence in the courtroom.

Conservative and liberal justices questioned whether Trump's order declaring that children born to parents who are in the United States illegally or temporarily are not American citizens comports with either the Constitution or federal law.

Arguments lasted more than two hours in a crowded courtroom that included not only Trump, the first sitting president to attend arguments at the nation's highest court, but also Attorney General Pam Bondi and Commerce Secretary Howard Lutnick, and in seats

reserved for the justices' guests, actor Robert De Niro.

The case frames another test of Trump's assertions of executive power that defy long-standing precedent for a court with a conservative majority and a robust view of presidential power, which has largely ruled in the Republican president's favour. In the notable exceptions when the court has not, Trump has responded with starkly personal criticisms of the justices. A definitive ruling is expected by early summer.

Trump, the media-savvy president, spent just over an hour inside a courtroom that prohibits cameras and all electronic devices for arguments made by the Republican administration's top Supreme Court lawyer, Solicitor General D John Sauer. The president departed shortly after lawyer Cecilia Wang began her presentation in defence of broad birthright citizenship.

After court adjourned, Trump posted on Truth Social: "We are the only Country in the World STUPID enough to allow Birthright Citizenship!" Actually, about three dozen countries, nearly all of them in the Americas, guarantee citizenship to chil-

dren born on their territory. Justices ask about the Trump order's legal basis: Trump heard Sauer face one sceptical question after another. Justices asked about the legal basis for the order and voiced more practical concerns.

"Is this happening in the delivery room?" Justice Ketanji Brown Jackson asked, drilling down into the logistics of how the government would actually figure out who is entitled to citizenship and who is not.

Chief Justice John Roberts suggested that Sauer was relying on quirky exceptions

to citizenship to make a broad argument about people who are in the country illegally. "I'm not quite sure how you can get to that big group from such tiny and sort of idiosyncratic examples," Roberts said.

Justice Clarence Thomas sounded the most likely among the nine justices to side with Trump.

"How much of the debates around the 14th Amendment had anything to do with immigration?" Thomas asked, pointing out that the purpose of the amendment was to grant citizenship to Black people, including freed slaves. Several courts have blocked the citizenship restrictions: The justices heard Trump's appeal of a lower-court ruling from New Hampshire that struck down the citizenship restrictions, one of several courts that have blocked them. The restrictions have not taken effect anywhere in the country. The birthright citizenship order, which Trump signed on the first day of his second term, is part of his Republican administration's broad immigration crackdown.

(AP)

Putin targets Armenia over EU membership

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Moscow

Russian President Vladimir Putin on Wednesday warned Armenia, which aspires to join the European Union, that it won't be able to be part of both the EU and a Moscow-led economic alliance.

Armenia, which signed a US-brokered agreement last year ending decades of hostilities with Azerbaijan, has increasingly sought to forge closer ties with the US and the EU. Armenian Prime Minister Nikol Pashinyan has declared an intention to join the EU, and his Government has suspended the country's participation in a Moscow-dominated security pact, the Collective Security Treaty Organisation.

Speaking at the start of talks with Pashinyan in Moscow, Putin said Russia is "absolutely calm" about Armenia's efforts to forge closer ties with the EU, but he noted that for Armenia "it's impossible to be in a customs union with the EU and the Eurasian Economic Union."

The Russia-led Eurasian

Economic Union, created in 2015 and also including Armenia, Belarus, Kazakhstan and Kyrgyzstan, is a single market allowing the free movement of goods, capitals and labour. Putin's statement appeared to send a warning signal as prospects for Armenia's EU membership look distant and no prospective tariff-free deal between Armenia and the EU has been discussed yet.

The Russian leader noted that the two blocs have widely different market regulations regarding various groups of goods and that reaching common ground is unlikely any time soon. He said it's up to Armenia to set its course, but he emphasised that the country is currently getting Russian natural gas at a much lower price compared to the European prices.

NORTHERN RAILWAY
(E-Auction Notice)

Sr. Divisional Commercial Manager/PS, Northern Railway Delhi Division invites bids through e-Auction through IREPS (<http://irops.gov.in/>) for the allotment of under mention contracts at following Railway stations/locations:

E-Catalogue No.	Date & Time of bidding	Railway Stations/Locations/Lots
Parking-11-2026	20.04.2026 at 11.00 Hrs	Kirti Nagar PRS = Total 01 Site

Website particulars where complete details of E-Auction can be seen

<https://irops.gov.in/>

All contractors who intend to participate in the e-auctions conducted through E-Auction Leasing module of IREPS should fulfill following mandatory requirements before they can submit their bids:

- Registration on IREPS for E-Auction Leasing module-Active IREPS User Account for E-Auction Leasing Module
- Payment of One Time Registration Fee
- Current Account in State Bank of India
- Integration of SBI Bank Account with IREPS Account
- Lien Marking of Funds
- Update of Turnover Details
- Contractors who do not have IREPS account for any module of IREPS can submit their online request for registration by clicking on New Vendors / Contractors (E-Tender/E-Auction Leasing) link on IREPS Home page.

Railway Authority
to contact, in case of any query

Divisional Railway Manager's Office,
Commercial Branch, State Entry Road, New Delhi 110055.
Email: pkg.delhidivision@gmail.com Tel: 011-23743084

No. 23AC/393/E-Auction/Pkg/2026 Dated: 02.04.2026

1113/2026

NORTHERN RAILWAY
Notice Inviting Application (NIA)

Notice Inviting Application (NIA) for the Engagement of Facilitator (Retired Railway Employee) for issuance of Unreserved Ticket through ATMV for a period of One Year at 47 Railway Stations over Delhi Division (File No. CIID/ATVM Facilitators/2026-2027)

1	Notice Inviting Application No.	CIID/ATVM Facilitators/2026-2027
2	Name of the work and its location	Engagement of Facilitator (Retired Railway Employee) for issuance of Unreserved Ticket through ATMV for a period of One Year at 47 Railway Stations i.e. NDLS, DLI, NZM, ANVT, DEE, DEC, PM, PTRD, NNO, SSB, GGN, DKZ, JIND, JHL, MSZ, NRW, TUN, ROK, BGZ, JNA, PNP, SNP, NUR, SZM, SMK, GNU, KUN, KKDE, DSA, NOLI, BPM, BTU, GZB, SBB, PWL, BVH, FDN, FDB, TKD, MTC, MDNR, MUD, MUT, DBD, MOZ, TPZ & SMOQL over Delhi Division.
3	Tender Type	Open Application
4	Address, Last Date & Time for submission of application through Offline mode	Applicants who wish to submit their applications offline may submit their application from 01.04.2026 to 14.04.2026 up to 17:00 hrs. in any working day, at the Commercial Branch, Office of the Divisional Railway Manager, State Entry Road, New Delhi-110055
5	E-Mail Address where applicants may submit application through Online mode	Applicants who wish to submit his/her application through Online, may submit their applications at the following official e-mail address: srdcm.ndls@gmail.com w.e.f. 01.04.2026 to 14.04.2026 up to 17:00 hrs.
6	List of documents to be submitted along with the application	1. Photocopy of latest PPO and Service Certificate (Self Attested). 2. Photocopy of Aadhaar Card (Self Attested). 3. Photocopy of PAN Card (Self attested). 4. Two passport size photographs.

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

1093/2026

PUBLIC NOTICE

(On behalf of our client Mr. Vikas Anand Singh) **Dissolution Of Partnership Firm M/s Neulife Healthcare Pharmaceuticals.** All concerned are hereby on this 31st Day of March 2026 , informed that the Partnership Firm M/s Neulife Healthcare Pharmaceuticals, having its office at H-10, Udayog Nagar, Rohtrak Road, Nangloi, Delhi, carrying on business of Medicine Wholesale, **STANDS DISSOLVED WITH EFFECT FROM 26th MARCH 2026** by mutual consent / notice under Section 43 of the Indian Partnership Act, 1932. The erstwhile partners of the said firm were: **1. Mr. Vikas Anand Singh** **2. Mr. Lovneet Gupta** All persons having any dealings with the firm are prohibited from entering into any transaction with any partner on behalf of the firm henceforth. Creditors and others having any claims against the firm are required to send particulars thereof to the undersigned within one month from the date of publication of this notice, failing which they shall be excluded from the benefits of any settlement under Section 45 of the Indian Partnership Act, 1932. All future communications/queries regarding the firm shall be addressed to: Mr. Vikas Anand Singh C/o Tarun K Bedi (Advocate/Mediator) 211, Vats Market, Pitampura, Delhi 110034 Ph:-9717461927/E-mail:-advoktbedi@gmail.com

PUBLIC NOTICE

Reg: DDA SFS Flat No. 157 on Ground Floor, Plinth area measuring 78.93 sq. mtrs., in Pocket-D, situated in the Triokpuri Residential Scheme, also known as Mayur Vihar Phase-II, Delhi-110091. Be it known to all that our clients, Mr. Deepak Dhawan & Ramesh Kumar (hereinafter called the "Purchasers") intend to purchase the said property from Mrs. Suman Bahri vide a Relinquishment Deed dated 23.03.2026 document no. 2026/4/2816 (hereinafter called the "Seller"). In this connection, the seller has informed that initially the said property owned by Mr. Chander Mohan Sharma through Conveyance Deed dated 14.06.2007 and thereafter the said property has been sold number of times and finally the said property has been sold to Mrs. Suman Bahri & Mr. Subhash Chander Bahri vide Sale Deed dated 14.12.2021 and after that Mr. Subhash Chander Bahri has expired on 19.11.2022 leaving behind legal heirs namely Mrs. Shalini Dhawan, Mrs. Shipra Arora, Mrs. Shweta Malhotra & Mrs. Suman Bahri. Thereafter, Mrs. Shalini Dhawan, Mrs. Shipra Arora, Mrs. Shweta Malhotra relinquished their respective shares in favour of Mrs. Suman Bahri as per Relinquishment deed as above. Hence, Mrs. Suman Bahri became the sole and absolute owner of the said property. The seller has also informed the purchasers that the said property is not mortgaged anywhere and there is no charge or dispute or any litigation pending regarding the said property. Any person including Banks, Financial Institutions, relatives having any claim, right, title or any interest of any nature whatsoever into or upon the aforesaid property is hereby called upon to make the same known, in writing, with documentary evidence, by Registered AD Post, to the undersigned at the address mentioned herein below within 07 days of publication of this notice and in the event of no response having been received to the notice, the title of the seller to the said property shall be deemed to be clear of any charge or encumbrance of any nature whatsoever and any subsequent claim shall not bind our clients/Purchasers, in any manner whatsoever. **Shivkant Arora, Advocate M/s Intelective Law Offices A-74, LGF, Defence Colony, New Delhi -110024**

Danish warship discovered on seabed of Copenhagen Harbour after 225 years

JAMES BROOKS ■ Copenhagen

More than 200 years after being sunk by Adm Horatio Nelson and the British fleet, a Danish warship has been discovered on the seabed of Copenhagen Harbour by marine archaeologists.

Working in thick sediment and almost zero visibility 15 metres (49 feet) beneath the waves, divers are working against the clock to unearth the 19th-century wreck of the Dannebroke before it becomes a construction site in a new housing district being built off the Danish coast. Denmark's Viking Ship Museum, which is leading the monthslong underwater excavations, announced its findings on Thursday, 225 years to the day since the Battle of Copenhagen in 1801.

"It's a big part of the Danish national feeling,"

said Morten Johansen, the museum's head of maritime archaeology. A great deal has been written about the battle "by very enthusiastic spectators, but we actually don't know how it was to be on board a ship being shot to pieces by English warships and some of that story we can probably learn from seeing the wreck", Johansen said. In the Battle of Copenhagen, Nelson and the British fleet attacked and defeated Denmark's navy as it formed a protec-

tive blockade outside the harbour.

Thousands were killed and wounded during the brutal hourslong naval clash, considered one of Nelson's "great battles". The intention was to force Denmark out of an alliance of Northern European powers, including Russia, Prussia and Sweden.

At the centre of the fighting was the Danish flagship, the Dannebroke, commanded by Commodore Olfert Fischer. (AP)

Iran fires missiles at Israel, Gulf neighbours

ASSOCIATED PRESS
Dubai

Iran responded to US President Donald Trump's address to Americans on the war with new missile attacks targeting Israel and the Gulf Arab states Thursday, underlining Tehran's insistence that it rejected Washington's outreach for a ceasefire while maintaining its grip on the Strait of Hormuz.

Britain planned to hold a call Thursday with nearly three dozen countries about how to reopen the strait, through which 20 per cent of all oil and natural gas traded passes in peacetime.

The 35 countries, including all G7 industrialised democracies except the US, as well as the United Arab Emirates and Bahrain, signed a declaration last month demanding Iran stop blocking the strait. The call will discuss "diplo-



matic and political measures" that could restore shipping once the fighting is over. Washington has insisted that Iran allow ships to freely transit the strait, but Trump this week has said it is not up

to the US to force it, and in his address encouraged countries that receive oil through Hormuz to "build some delayed courage" and go "take it."

In his address, Trump said

the US would hit Iran "extremely hard over the next two to three weeks," while also insisting American "core strategic objectives are nearing completion."

Just before Trump began

his nearly 20-minute address on Wednesday, explosions were heard in Dubai as air defences worked to intercept an Iranian missile barrage. Less than a half hour after the president was done, Israel said its military was working to intercept incoming missiles. Sirens sounded in Bahrain, home to the US Navy's 5th Fleet, immediately after the speech.

Death toll continues to rise: More than 1,900 people have been killed in Iran during the war, while 19 have been reported dead in Israel. More than two dozen people have died in Gulf states and the occupied West Bank, while 13 US service members have been killed.

More than 1,200 people have been killed in Lebanon and more than 1 million displaced, according to authorities. Ten Israeli soldiers have also died there.

Earthquake off Indonesia topples buildings, kills 1, sets off small tsunami

ASSOCIATED PRESS
Manado (Indonesia)

An undersea earthquake of 7.4 magnitude toppled buildings in parts of northern Indonesia, sent people fleeing from their homes, killed at least one person and generated a small tsunami Thursday.

Waves up to 75 cm (30 inches) above normal tides were recorded at several monitoring stations about a half-hour after the earthquake, which was centred in the Molucca Sea. Indonesia's meteorological agency lifted its tsunami warning hours after the quake, and the Philippine Institute of Volcanology and Seismology said there was no destructive threat to the country, which is north of the quake's epicentre. Strong shaking lasting 10 to 20 seconds was felt in



Bitung in North Sulawesi province as well as in Ternate city in neighbouring North Maluku province, according to Indonesia's Disaster Management Agency.

Initial assessments showed light to severe damage in parts of Ternate, including a church and two houses. In Bitung, damage assessments were still underway, the agency said. Indonesia's Search and Rescue Agency reported a

70-year-old woman died in a building collapse in North Sulawesi's Manado city and another resident was injured. At least three injured people were hospitalised in Ternate. Videos released by the rescue agency showed damaged structures and flattened houses, while television stations broadcast scenes of people rushing outside and gathering in streets to avoid the risk of collapsing buildings.

Artemis II astronauts in moon orbit

MARCIA DUNNAP
Cape Canaveral (US)

Four astronauts embarked on a high-stakes flight around the moon on Wednesday, humanity's first lunar voyage in more than half a century and the thrilling leadoff in NASA's push toward a landing in two years.

Carrying three Americans and one Canadian, the 32-story rocket rose from NASA's Kennedy Space Centre where tens of thousands gathered to witness the dawn of this new era. Crowds also jammed the surrounding roads and beaches, reminiscent of the Apollo moonshots in the 1960s and '70s. It is NASA's biggest step yet toward establishing a permanent lunar presence.

"On this historic mission, you take with you the heart of this Artemis team, the daring spirit of the American people and our partners across the globe, and the hopes and dreams of a new generation," launch director Charlie Blackwell-Thompson told the crew right before liftoff. "Good luck, Godspeed Artemis II. Let's go."

Artemis II set sail from the same Florida launch site that sent Apollo's explorers to the moon so long ago. The handful still alive cheered this next generation's grand adventure as the Space Launch System rocket thundered into the early evening



sky, a nearly full moon beckoning some 248,000 miles (400,000 km) away.

Five minutes into the flight, Commander Reid Wiseman saw the team's target: "We have a beautiful moonrise, we're headed right at it," he said from the capsule.

On board with him are pilot Victor Glover, Christina Koch and Canada's Jeremy Hansen. It is the most diverse lunar crew ever with the first woman, person of colour and non-US citizen riding in NASA's new Orion capsule.

"NASA is back in the business of sending astronauts to

the moon," NASA Administrator Jared Isaacman told reporters following liftoff, calling the half-century hiatus a brief intermission.

Tensions were high earlier in the day as hydrogen fuel started flowing into the rocket. Dangerous hydrogen leaks erupted during a countdown test earlier this year, forcing a lengthy flight delay.

To NASA's relief, no significant hydrogen leaks occurred. The launch team loaded more than 700,000 gallons of fuel (2.6 million litres) into the 32-story Space Launch System rocket on the

pad, a smooth operation that set the stage for the Artemis II crew to board.

Then NASA had to overcome a flurry of last-minute technical issues — bad battery sensors and an inability to get commands through to the rocket's flight termination system. In both cases, the issues were quickly resolved, allowing the launch to proceed.

The astronauts will stick close to home for the first 25 hours of their 10-day test flight, checking out the capsule in orbit around Earth before firing the main engine that will propel them to the moon. They won't pause for a stopover or orbit the moon like Apollo 8's first lunar visitors did so famously on Christmas Eve 1968, reading from Genesis.

But they stand to become the most distant humans ever when their capsule zooms past the moon and continues another 4,000 miles (6,400 km) beyond, before making a U-turn and tearing straight home to a splashdown in the Pacific.

Once settled in a high orbit around Earth, the astronauts assumed manual control and practiced steering their capsule around the rocket's detached upper stage, venturing as close as 33 feet (10 metres). NASA wants to know how Orion handles in case the self-flying feature fails and the pilots need to take control.

New Zealand, Cook Islands sign defence pact

ASSOCIATED PRESS
Wellington

New Zealand and Cook Islands signed a defence and security pact Thursday, easing more than a year of tension between the Pacific nations over Cook Islands' deepening ties with China.

The fraught diplomatic standoff that prompted Wellington to pause millions of dollars in aid to Avarua was hardly a clash of geopolitical heavyweights: New Zealand has a population of 5 million, while Cook Islands has 15,000 people.

But the lengthy freeze gripped Pacific observers because it reflected the struggle confronting tiny island nations with close ties to Western countries such as New Zealand and Australia as they seek to balance their traditional alliances with overtures from Beijing.

In the new declaration, Cook Islands pledged New Zealand would be its "partner of choice regarding defense and security matters," apparently quashing the prospect, feared by Wellington, of China occupying the role. It resolved "ambiguity" about the two countries' existing ties, New Zealand Foreign Minister Winston Peters said.

When Cook Islands Prime Minister Mark Brown inked a comprehensive strategic



partnership between his country and China during a visit to Beijing in February 2025, it provoked alarm in Wellington because Brown wouldn't divulge the content of the deal first, a refusal New Zealand officials said could have security implications. Cook Islands is a self-governing country with a 60-year free association relationship to New Zealand, which means it's defended by New Zealand's military and citizens can live and work freely in New Zealand.

The links require Cook Islands leaders to consult with Wellington on deals with other countries that might affect New Zealand. Brown defended his decision not to disclose the contents of his pact with China, which

he said was unnecessary under his country's existing accords with Wellington.

New Zealand — which is Cook Islands' biggest benefactor — froze millions of dollars in aid over the episode, although it wasn't a large amount of the total funding that Wellington contributes. That aid would now flow again, Peters told reporters during a visit to Cook Islands on Thursday, where he and Brown signed the new agreement.

"This declaration seeks to remove previous ambiguity about the nature of the relationship between New Zealand and the Cook Islands, especially as it pertains to defense and security," Peters said. Cook Islands, an archipelago of 15 islands

in the vast South Pacific Ocean, is among many small nations in the region to be courted by Beijing, which has offered aid, loans and deals throughout the Pacific to increase its sway.

The sparsely populated South Pacific is considered strategically important and many of its countries, including Cook Islands, have large and lucrative exclusive economic zones, where Brown is exploring prospects for mining of deep sea minerals.

"The strategic environment we face is more complex and contested today than at any other point since New Zealand and the Cook Islands formed our free association relationship in 1965," Peters said Thursday.

US: Nebraska adopts resolution recognising celebration of Diwali

YOSHITA SINGH
New York

The Nebraska State Legislature in the US has adopted a resolution recognising the celebration of Deepavali, in what the Indian mission in Seattle described as a "historic" move for the state's Hindu community.

The resolution was sponsored by State Senator John Frederickson and signed by Speaker John Arch on March 31. The adoption of the resolution is a "historic" development for the Indian diaspora in the American Midwest and marks a "watershed moment" for the approximately 9,000 Hindus who call the "Cornhusker State" (Nebraska's official nickname) home, the Consulate General of India in Seattle said in a statement. The Consulate noted that



Frederickson, whose district includes the Hindu Temple of Omaha established in 1993, has been a "long-time ally" of the community, frequently attending temple events.

While Hindus account for less than one per cent of Nebraska's population, the passage of resolution LR 424 signals an "era of deep cultur-

al integration and respect," it said. The resolution also sets the stage for a grand Diwali celebration to be hosted by Governor Jim Pillen at the Governor's Mansion on October 20 this year. "Historic Legislative Recognition of Deepavali in Nebraska! Nebraska adopts State Legislative Resolution (SLR)

424, recognising the celebration of Deepavali and its significance to all Nebraskans," the Indian mission said in a post on X. The Consulate expressed gratitude to Fredrickson for "piloting the legislation" and thanked members of the Indian American community for their support. The resolution states that "Deepavali is a uniting force, as it is celebrated by the majority of people from India, regardless of their faith, and is celebrated by more than one billion people worldwide". It noted that the festival is recognised as an "enduring" symbol of the triumph of goodness, light, and knowledge over evil and darkness. Highlighting that the vibrant Hindu community contributes tremendously to the vitality of the State of Nebraska by enriching the

lives of its citizens, the resolution said: "The Legislature recognises the celebration of Deepavali and its significance to all Nebraskans who celebrate the holiday."

"The glow of the diya now shines brighter in Nebraska, reflecting a state that increasingly views its small but mighty Indian-American community as a cornerstone of its cultural identity," the Consulate said. The development is the latest in a string of symbolic gestures that highlight the strengthening bonds between Nebraska and India. In December 2024, Governor Pillen and India's Consul General in Seattle, Prakash Gupta, installed a bust of Mahatma Gandhi at the State Capitol, the first such installation in any State Capitol within the Consulate's jurisdiction. (PTI)

Democrats sue to block Trump's executive order targeting mail ballots

NICHOLAS RICCARDI
Washington

Democrats sued Wednesday to block President Donald Trump's latest executive order restricting mail voting, arguing that the US Constitution empowers states and Congress, not the president, to determine who is eligible to vote by mail.

The lawsuit marks the second round of battles over the president's power to control elections. Trump's opponents handily won the first round last year, blocking his initial executive order intended to reshape election procedures by convincing multiple federal judges that it was likely unconstitutional. Trump on Tuesday announced that his admin-



istration would compile lists of who is eligible to vote in states and that the US Postal Service would only mail ballots to those who met that criteria.

Critics note that there's little time to comb through voter rolls before ballots start going out for this fall's

elections, in some places as soon as September, and question whether the administration's list would be reliable. Mail voting has existed for more than a century and had steadily been increasing in popularity in both Democratic and Republican states until 2020.

Man charged in connection with deaths of dozens of women

JUAN A LOZANO
Houston (US)

Prosecutors have charged a man allegedly connected to some of the deaths linked to the "Texas Killing Fields", an area near Houston where the bodies of dozens of women were found beginning in the 1970s, saying they have solved a piece of a tragic mystery that has inspired books, movies and a Netflix documentary.

A stretch of land along Interstate 45 southeast of Houston was dubbed the "Texas Killing Fields" after the bodies of more than 30 women were found there. Investigators believe multiple

perpetrators may be responsible for the deaths of mainly girls and young women.

A Galveston grand jury has indicted 61-year-old James Dolphs Elmore Jr for his alleged role in the deaths of 16-year-old Laura Miller and 30-year-old Audrey Cook, whose bodies were found in the infamous area in 1986, Galveston County District Attorney Kenneth Cusick said Wednesday.

Court and jail records did not list an attorney who could speak on behalf of Elmore, who was arrested Tuesday and is being held without bond in the Galveston County jail. Miller and Cook were two of four young women whose

bodies were found between 1984 and 1991 in a rural field off a desolate dirt road in League City, located about 45 km southeast of Houston. The other two women were 25-year-old Heidi Fye-Villareal and 34-year-old Donna Prudhomme.

Cusick said after being appointed as district attorney in October that he would take a harder look at these cases. "Due to the concerted efforts of the law enforcement agencies in this county, this 40-year cycle of violence by these defendants against women, we're trying to make headway on it, and I think we made significant headway yesterday in getting a charge



against Mr Elmore and having him arrested," he said.

Elmore has been charged with manslaughter and felony tampering with evidence in the death of Miller and with tampering with evi-

dence in Cook's killing. Cusick said prosecutors had also presented evidence to a grand jury seeking indictments against Clyde Hedrick, who authorities allege was the person responsible for

the deaths of the four women and had been Elmore's long-time friend. But the 72-year-old Hedrick died by suicide last month before the grand jury came back with a decision in his case, Cusick said.

Hedrick was convicted of manslaughter in 2014 in the death of Ellen Beason, a young woman whose body was found in 1985 after going missing the previous years. He was released in 2022 and was still on parole at the time of his death, according to the Texas Department of Criminal Justice.

Relatives of the victims on Wednesday said they were relieved an arrest had been made but expressed frustra-

tion it had taken so long.

"I think with everything that they had in the past, it's inexcusable that Clyde Hedrick had the opportunity to die without never been indicted, convicted," said Tim Miller, the father of Laura Miller. After his daughter's death, Miller founded Texas EquuSearch, a nonprofit that helps look for missing people. Miller said in the last four years, he had met 30 times with Elmore who had shared information but he declined to elaborate on what Elmore told him because he didn't want to jeopardise the case against him. Nina Jager, Fye-Villareal's niece, celebrated Elmore's indictment but said it was also "bittersweet"

because her grandfather had investigated the case and long believed Hedrick was responsible but his efforts were ignored by authorities.

"Maybe today is a result of all the work that he put in, all the searching the fields, going and talking to people and doing his own investigation because he just didn't feel supported," she said. Cusick said he's committed to continue working on these cases and that there are active leads that can be pursued "to bring to justice some people who may have escaped justice thus far," he said. Most of the deaths associated with the "Texas Killing Fields" remain unsolved. (AP)

Gen Neeraj Shukla on assuming command of the Gajraj Corps. He also commended Lt Gen Gambhir Singh for his exemplary leadership and significant contributions during his tenure. The change of command underscores the Indian Army's continued commitment to operational excellence, professional leadership, and steadfast service to the nation.

Former Chief Election Commissioner SY Quraishi called for systemic reforms to restore confidence in the electoral process. He recommended forensic audits of Form 17C and Form 20, and stressed that polling percentage data should be released on the same day in accordance with established norms.

NTPC achieved 105% ash utilisation, utilising 109 Million Metric Tonnes (MMT) of ash. This outstanding performance reinforces NTPC's leadership in sustainable practices and circular resource management.

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3, T-went-y	16, Treat
4, Yak	18, T-rial
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7, Ogre	22, T-I-rade
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12, Given	25, He-L-P-y
13, C-ouch	26, A-LSO
14, P-lead	28, T-en

As Jaipur continues to grow as a satellite tech hub, Dutta's advocacy serves as a case study for thousands of IT professionals facing the reality of a changing workplace. His journey underscores that while a degree may open the door, only adaptive intelligence will keep it from closing in an increasingly automated world.

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BRIEFLY

Arsenal reach Women’s Champions League semifinals



KAREL JANICEK ■ London

Defending champion Arsenal advanced to the Women’s Champions League semifinals despite a 1-0 loss to Chelsea in a London derby. With a 3-1 home victory in the first leg of the quarterfinal last week, Arsenal reached the last four on a 3-2 aggregate score and will next face either Wolfsburg or Lyonnes. Sjoek Nusen scored for Chelsea from close rage in the fourth minute of stoppage time at Stamford Bridge on Wednesday.

In the dramatic last few minutes, Veele Buurman hit the post for Chelsea and Arsenal goalkeeper Daphne van Domselaar saved a goal-bound header by Nusken. Chelsea coach Sonia Bompastor received a red card in the dying seconds of the match. The home team was pressuring Arsenal from the start with forward Sam Kerr particularly posing a threat. Kerr missed the first leg because she was playing for Australia at the Asian Cup.

Bayern’s late comeback: Earlier, Bayern Munich rallied with two late goals in three minutes to beat Manchester United 2-1 and advance to the semifinals on a 5-3 aggregate score.

Glodis Viggosdottir started the rally in the 81st with a header after a corner kick, and Linda Dallmann fired from inside the area after another corner to send Bayern to its first semifinal since 2021.

It’s World Cup audition time in Bundesliga



ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Berlin

It’s crunch time for a host of Bundesliga players with ambitions of playing at the World Cup.

Bayern Munich 18-year-old midfielder Lennart Karl is fighting to keep his spot for Germany, Deniz Undav’s scoring streak for Stuttgart has put pressure on coach Julian Nagelsmann to take him to the US in June, and Alejandro Grimaldo’s form for Bayer Leverkusen could help him earn a spot for Spain.

Oh, and there’s still a title to be won. Bayern comes back into action after the international break with a vast 11-point lead over Borussia Dortmund. If Bayern wins its next two games and Dortmund loses both, the title could be Bayern’s as soon as April 11.

Key matchups: Dortmund heads to Stuttgart needing points to keep pace with Bayern. Stuttgart’s third, chasing Champions League qualification, and with a host of players chasing World Cup spots for Germany like Undav, Angelo Stiller, Jamie Leweling and Chris Fuhrich. Dortmund’s Carney Chukwuemeka’s just made his Austria debut, too.

Praggnanandhaa held by Bluebaum

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Paphos (Cyprus)

Grandmaster R Praggnanandhaa played out a draw with German Matthias Bluebaum while Uzbekistan’s Javokhir Sindarov grabbed sole lead after defeating pre-event favourite Fabiano Caruana of the USA in the fourth round of the Candidates chess tournament.

World Cup winner last year, Sindarov took his tally to 3.5 points with his third victory in four games here on Wednesday and this could well prove to be vital in securing a title match with reigning world champion D Gukesh later this year.

After losing to Sindarov in the previous round, Praggnanandhaa was in recovery mode and did not have any trouble in securing the draw as black against Bluebaum.

With 10 rounds still to come, Sindarov is still followed by Caruana in sole second spot on 2.5 points while Praggnanandhaa, along with Bluebaum and Anish Giri of Holland, is on joint third spot with two points.

In other two games of the day, Anish Giri bounced back and defeated Russian Andrey Esipenko while Wei Yi of China played out a draw with American Hikaru Nakamura.

In the women’s event Divya Deshmukh suffered a setback at the hands of Chinese Jiner Zhu and R Vaishali played out a draw with Aleksandra Goryachkina of Russia.

Last minute replacement following Koneru Humpy’s withdraw-



al, Anna Muzychuk of Ukraine joined overnight leader Bibisara Assaubayev of Kazakhstan in pole position at the expense of Kateryna Lagno of Russia while Zhongyi Tan’s hunt for an elusive victory continued after a draw with the Kazakh talent.

Muzychuk and Assaubayeva share the lead on 2.5 points apiece and are followed by Vaishali, Goryachkina, Zhu and Lagno on two points each.

Zhongyi and Divya are not far behind with 1.5 points and one can hope for more fireworks after the first rest day. Praggnanandhaa started off with the Semi Slav defense as black inviting massive complications but Bluebaum decided not to test the Indian in his own playground.

The result was a solid opening from white that did not give any chances and routine exchanges

led to a draw opposite coloured Bishops endgame. For once, Divya Deshmukh’s plans did not work well as she fell in to a worse position out of the opening against Jiner Zhu. The Chinese picked up a couple of pawns before securing her first victory in the tournament.

Results round 4: Matthias Bluebaum (Ger, 2) drew with R Praggnanandhaa (Ind, 2); Javokhir Sindarov (Uzb, 3.5) beat Fabiano Caruana (Usa, 2.5); Andrey Esipenko (Rus, 1) lost to Anish Giri (Ned, 2); Wei Yi (Chn, 1.5) drew with Hikaru Nakamura (Usa, 1.5).

Women: Bibisara Assaubayeva (Kaz, 2.5) drew with Zhongyi Tan (Chn, 1.5); Divya Deshmukh (Ind, 1.5) lost to Jiner Zhu (Chn, 2); Anna Muzychuk (Ukr, 2.5) beat Kateryna Lagno (Rus, 2); R Vaishali (Ind, 2) drew with Aleksandra Goryachkina (Rus, 2).

Tiger Woods turns down Ryder Cup captaincy

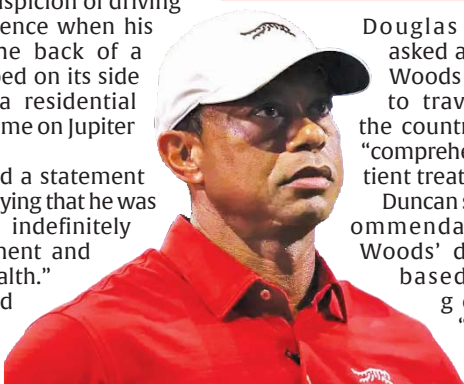
DOUG FERGUSON ■ New York

Tiger Woods formally turned down the Ryder Cup captaincy Wednesday as he steps away from golf activities, and a Florida judge approved his motion to leave the country to seek treatment. The developments come one day after Woods entered a not guilty plea to suspicion of driving under the influence when his SUV clipped the back of a trailer and flipped on its side last week on a residential road near his home on Jupiter Island, Florida.

Woods posted a statement Tuesday night saying that he was stepping away indefinitely “to seek treatment and focus on his health.”

A motion filed Wednesday by his attorney,

TIGER WOODS FORMALLY TURNED DOWN THE RYDER CUP CAPTAINCY AND A FLORIDA JUDGE APPROVED HIS MOTION TO LEAVE THE COUNTRY TO SEEK TREATMENT



Douglas Duncan, asked a judge that Woods be allowed to travel outside the country to begin “comprehensive inpatient treatment.”

Duncan said the recommendation from Woods’ doctor was based on the golfer’s “complex clinical

presentation and the urgent need for a level of care that cannot safely or effectively be done within the United States as his privacy has been repeatedly compromised.” “Ongoing medical scrutiny and public exposure create significant barriers to his care and would result in setbacks and an inability to fully engage in treatment.” Martin County Court Judge Darren Steele approved the motion, which did not say where the inpatient treatment facility was located.

Woods sought treatment at an inpatient facility in Mississippi clinic in January 2010 after he was caught in a series of extramarital affairs, and his agent said he sought treatment at another inpatient clinic after his 2017 DUI arrest. “I’m committed to taking the time needed to return in a healthier, stronger, and more focused place, both personally and professionally,” Woods said. (AP)

Marin and Oh share lead at Augusta National Women’s Amateur

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Evans (US)

Arkansas junior Maria Jose Marin birdied her final two holes for a 7-under 65 to share the lead with 17-year-old Soomin Oh of South Korea in an opening round of great weather and low scoring at Champions Retreat in the Augusta National Women’s Amateur.

Asterisk Talley, the 17-year-old Californian who was runner-up in the ANWA a year ago, holed a greenside bunker shot for eagle on the par-5 18th hole as she made the turn and shot 66.

The conditions were ideal, and most of the 72-player field seized on the opportunity. Eight players were at 67 or lower, and 31 players broke par.

Marin, the 19-year-old Colombian who won the NCAA title last year, finished on the back and poured in



an 8-foot birdie putt to get off to a much better start than a year ago, when she failed to make the 36-hole cut.

The second round on Thursday is at Champions Retreat, and the top

30 and ties advance to the final round Saturday at Augusta National. All 72 players get to play at the home of the Masters on Friday.

“I feel like last year ... it was a lot of learning,” Marin said.

“There was a lot of tears, and of course this tournament means a lot to me. Not making the cut, it hurt a lot. But I learned that I’ve got to stay with my two feet on the ground, that I have to be really patient with my game, that if things are not going my way, I don’t have to push it, that I just have to wait for golf to do its thing.”

Oh, the runner-up in the Women’s Amateur Asia-Pacific earlier this year, also played bogey-free. She was on the front edge of the green on the par-5 ninth, facing a 70-foot eagle chance to take the lead. She did well to lag it 4 feet beyond the cup and holed that to share the lead.

Andrea Revuelta and Vanessa Borovilos joined Talley at 66. The group at 67 included Meja Ortengren and A m e l i e Zalsman, the 17-year-old Floridian who earlier this year

won the prestigious South Atlantic Women’s Amateur.

Revuelta and Ortengren are among all five players from Stanford in the field, four of whom broke par. The exception was US Women’s Amateur champion Megha Ganne, who was stunned by two double bogeys in her opening four holes and crashed to a 77.

This is Ganne’s sixth time playing the ANWA, which already has become as prestigious as any amateur event in women’s golf, mainly because of where the final round is played.

Talley first rose to some level of national prominence in 2024 when she reached the championship match of three USGA events, including the US Women’s Amateur and US Girls Junior. Talley is coming off a tie for 29th last week in the Ford Championship on the LPGA.



FIFA raises top ticket price for WC final

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Zurich

FIFA raised its top ticket price for the World Cup final to \$10,990 during the glitch-hampered reopening of sales after the 48-team field for this year’s tournament was finalised.

The price had been \$8,680 when FIFA sold tickets after the tournament draw in December.

FIFA’s category 2 tickets for the July 19 game at MetLife Stadium in East Rutherford, New Jersey, were \$7,380, up from \$5,575, and category 3 cost \$5,785, an increase \$4,185.

Tickets were listed for 17 of the 72 group-stage matches by Wednesday night and none of the knockout stage games.

Soccer’s governing body is using dynamic pricing for the tournament, which will be played in 11 US cities plus three in Mexico and two in Canada.

Only \$2,735 tickets, the highest-priced seats, were available by evening for the US opener on June 12 against Paraguay at SoFi Stadium in Inglewood, California, and the price was unchanged from December. No tickets were listed for the Americans’ June 19 game against Australia at Seattle or their June 25 match against Turkey at Inglewood.

Only \$2,985 seats were available by Wednesday evening for the tournament opener between Mexico and Saudi Arabia on June 11 in Mexico City, up from \$2,355 in December. And only \$2,240 tickets were available for Canada’s first game on June 12 against Bosnia-Herzegovina in Toronto, an increase from \$2,170.

Soccer’s governing body did not announce which games

and price categories were available, leaving potential ticket buyers to search themselves on a FIFA ticketing site that often took hours to enter.

Some people who clicked on what FIFA called its “last-minute sales phase” when sales opened at 11 am EDT were directed into a queue for “PMA late qualifier supporters sales phase,” aimed for a segment of fans for the six nations who earned berths on Tuesday. FIFA did not have an



explanation for why the link misdirection occurred but said around noon that the links were working properly.

FIFA also said that not all remaining tickets were being put on sale for the 104 games to be played in the US, Mexico and Canada from June 11 to July 19 and that additional tickets will be released on a rolling basis.

This was the fifth phase of ticket sales following a Visa presale draw from September 10-19, an early ticket draw from October 27-31, a random selection draw from December 11 to January 13 and an unscheduled 48-hour availability in late February.

FIFA said this phase, which will remain open through the tournament, marked the first time a specific seat location could be purchased rather than a request for a ticket in a category. For the month-long sales phase after the December 5 draw, tickets were priced at \$140 to \$8,680.

US players on World Cup have fear of missing out

RONALD BLUM ■ Atlanta

Now comes the wait, soccer’s ultimate FOMO.

American players across the United States and Europe will count down the eight weeks until coach Mauricio Pochettino picks his 26 World Cup players.

Those bypassed won’t get a phone call. “It’s going to be painful,” Pochettino said.

“In that process, always you create links, no, emotional links, but it’s going to be difficult to pick 26 from 35, 40 players.”

Twenty-four players were used during the 5-2 loss to Belgium and 2-0 defeat to Portugal in the last two friendlies before Pochettino announces his roster on May 26 at an event in New York. A total of 38 players have appeared in the last eight matches dating to September.

Twelve players appear to be locks if healthy: goalkeepers Matt Freese and Matt Turner; right back Sergino Dest; central defenders Tim Ream and Chris Richards; left back Antonee Robinson; midfielders Tyler Adams, Weston McKennie and Malik Tillman;



attackers Christian Pulisic and Timothy Weah; and forward Folarin Balogun.

About two dozen others are possible: goalkeepers Chris Brady, Patrick Schulte and Jonathan Klinsmann; central defenders Mark McKenzie, Miles Robinson and Auston Trusty; outside backs Max Arsten, Alex Freeman, Joe Scally and John Tolkin; midfielders Brenden Aaronson, Sebastian Berhalter, Johnny Cardoso, Diego Luna, Jack McGlynn, Aiden Morris, Gio Reyna, Cristian Roldan and Tanner

Tessmann; and forwards Patrick Agyemang, Ricardo Pepi, Haji Wright and Alejandro Zendejas.

Players will be concentrating on their club careers and as May 26 approaches will try not to dwell on their World Cup chances.

“Hopefully that time when with Celtic we’re playing (the Scottish) Cup final. That’s the only thing I’ll be focusing on,” defender Trusty said.

Failure to win the CONCACAF Gold Cup and pro-visiting team crowds in the US amped up anxiety among

fans and the former-player pundit class throughout the summer, but ending the year with a five-game unbeaten streak boosted belief.

This month’s losses sent skepticism soaring. “I think we’re heading in the right direction. I think obviously it’s hard to say that we’re where we want to be with results like this, but I think that we take a lot of positives away from the games that we played,” McKennie said.

“We see that we can keep up. I think we just need to figure out how to be able to stay in the game if we don’t finish chances that we have early on.”

Pulisic hasn’t scored in a career-high eight straight national team games and also is scoreless in 12 matches for AC Milan since December 28. “He just needs one to go in, get back on that wave,” US career scoring co-leader Clint Dempsey said. “Everybody goes through a little bit of a slump.”

Pochettino cautioned that US players are not as good as some American fans think they are, pointing to the latest results. (AP)

Salah begins farewell tour with Liverpool

STEVE DOUGLAS ■ Liverpool

Mohamed Salah’s long goodbye to Liverpool begins on Saturday in the quarterfinals of the FA Cup, the competition which represents his best chance of a trophy in his final year at Anfield.

The Egypt winger announced last week that he will be leaving Liverpool at the end of the season after nine years at a club where he has broken scoring records and established himself as one of the world’s best players.

Salah potentially has 15 games left in the famous red shirt: Seven in the Premier League as well as three in the FA Cup and five in the Champions League, should Liverpool reach the final in both of those competitions.

That won’t be easy.

In the Champions League, defending champion Paris Saint-Germain is up next in the two-leg quarterfinals and it’s pretty much as tough in the FA Cup, with Liverpool handed an away match at Manchester City.

Salah, who has 255 goals in 435 appearances for Liverpool, missed the Reds’



last game before the international break — a 2-1 loss at Brighton in the league — with a muscle injury but has told manager Arne Slot he should be healthy enough to return this weekend.

“He just does so much for his body for such a long time that he recovers so fast,” Slot said on Wednesday. “So, he will train with the team again tomorrow and if everything works well then he’s

available to be with us at City.” The 33-year-old Salah was left out of the Liverpool team for four straight games at the end of 2025 in what appeared to be a breakdown in his relationship with Slot and the club.

Since returning from the Africa Cup of Nations, Salah virtually has been an ever-present in the lineup, seemingly winning the Dutch coach round.

“That hunger never drops,” Slot said of Salah. “It’s the thing I find most special about him. So many good players around the world — he’s definitely one of them in the last 10 years — and to show that hunger every three days, that professionalism, that commitment to the club and to the team, wanting to score again, always wanting to play ...

KKR slump continues as Klaasen guides SRH to victory

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Kolkata

Heinrich Klaasen's experience-driven half-century guided Sunrisers Hyderabad back to winning ways as they thrashed Kolkata Knight Riders by 65 runs in their IPL clash here on Thursday.

Blessing Muzarabani grabbed 4/41 but it was Klaasen's composed 52 off 35 balls that held Sunrisers Hyderabad's innings together as they posted a competitive 226/8 after KKR opted to bowl.

Chasing the daunting target, KKR never found momentum as they were bundled out for 161 and slumped to their second successive defeat, having lost their opening match to Mumbai Indians at the Wankhede.

Boasting a batting-heavy lineup

in Finn Allen, IPL's costliest overseas buy Cameron Green (Rs 25.20-crore), Rinku Singh and Sunil Narine, the target at the free-flowing Eden looked par.

It needed a partnership in the middle but there were clear signs of a lack of chemistry in the KKR line-up as they lasted just 16 overs.

That their mystery spinner Varun Chakravarthy leaked 25 runs in one over and returned with 0/31 from two overs also hurt them. Narine (0/39) also returned worthless from his four overs.

For SRH, left-arm pacer Jaydev Unadkat took 3/21 from three overs that included the wicket of Rahane, while Ehsan Malinga (2/14 in two overs) and Nitish Kumar Reddy (2/17 in two overs) were also effective.



KKR's veteran skipper Ajinkya Rahane's painful eight off 10 balls once again raised questions over the team's bold leadership call, while partnerships failed to materialise. Youngster Angkrish Raghuvanshi showed promise with a breezy 52 (29 balls; 6x4, 2x6) but there was no support from the other end. Fresh from his 100 not out in the T20 World Cup semi-final against South Africa a month ago on the same wicket, Kiwi opener Finn Allen showed early sparks in a seven-ball 28 (4x4, 2x6).

But once he fell to Harsh Dubey giving a return catch, the innings unravelled quickly.

KKR's star recruit Green endured another failure, run out for two, following a chaotic mix-up with Raghuvanshi who played

the shot. But Malinga stopped the ball with his foot and Green was off the crease. Raghuvanshi started walking but review showed Green hasn't crossed so the Aussie had to depart.

The confusion did not end there. Raghuvanshi, who top-scored for KKR, was involved in yet another mix-up and was run out, summing up KKR's plight. Half the side was back in the pavilion soon after Anukul Roy's dismissal, leaving the chase in tatters. Vice-captain Rinku Singh offered brief resistance with a 35 off 25 balls, but his dismissal to Reddy ended any lingering hopes.

Walking in after a dramatic middle-over slide from being 110/1 in eight overs to 118/4 in 9.2 overs, Klaasen rebuilt the innings with calm assurance, ensuring the run

rate never dipped out of control.

Even as boundaries dried up, the seasoned South African smartly rotated strike and ran hard between the wickets, keeping SRH around the 11-run mark alongside Nitish Kumar Reddy (39; 24 balls) in a match-deciding 82 runs alliance off 53 balls.

The duo put on 50 run together in just 36 balls, with Klaasen striking four fours and a six in his composed 52 off 35 deliveries as they maintained the tempo set by their opening duo of Travis Head (46; 21 balls) and Abhishek sharma (48; 21 balls). The SRH opening duo raced to an 82-run opening stand in just 34 deliveries, propelling the side to nearly 15 runs per over as KKR's inexperience with the ball started to haunt them.

Foden not guaranteed a place in England's WC squad: Tuchel

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ London

England coach Thomas Tuchel has confirmed that Phil Foden is not a sure thing to make the World Cup squad. The Manchester City player started both of England's friendly games in the final camp before Tuchel selects his squad for this summer's tournament.

England lost to Japan 1-0 on Tuesday at Wembley Stadium, after last Friday's 1-1 draw with Uruguay.

The 25-year-old Foden played as a number 10 against Uruguay before being used as a "false nine" against Japan. Tuchel said Foden was "excellent in camp" but "he struggles to show it on the pitch."



The German coach added: "Well, it's not a guarantee that he will come."

Cole Palmer also failed to impress on Tuesday. With Morgan Rogers and Jude Bellingham other options as attacking midfielders, Palmer and Foden face anxious waits to see if they make the plane for the tournament.

MCA president meets officials for one lakh capacity stadium

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Mumbai

Mumbai cricket chief Ajinkya Naik has met officials of the State Government to expedite the development of a one lakh capacity stadium in the Mumbai Metropolitan Region (MMR).

Naik recently met officials from City And Industrial Development Corporation Of Maharashtra Ltd (CIDCO) to discuss the mega project that has been proposed for a while.

"This initiative marks a defining moment for Maharashtra's sporting



ecosystem. A 1 lakh capacity stadium in the Mumbai Metropolitan Region will not only elevate Mumbai cricket but also firmly position Maharashtra on the global sporting map.

Aditya delivered a win at Asian Boxing Championships

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Ulaanbaatar (Mongolia)

India's Aditya delivered a commanding win on day 4 of the Asian Boxing Championships here.

Competing in the men's 65kg category, Aditya, the National Champion who recently clinched gold at the ninth Elite Men's National Boxing Championship in January 2026, secured a 5-0 unanimous decision victory over Mousa Alhawsaw of Saudi Arabia, showcasing control and precision throughout the bout.

With this win, Aditya advances to the next round, where he will face



Uzbekistan's Abdulloh Madaminov in what promises to be a competitive contest. The event features top talent from across the continent, with Indian boxers building strong momentum in the tournament.

CSK seek rhythm against potent PK

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Chennai

Chennai Super Kings will need to improve significantly in all departments of the game to trouble a potent Punjab Kings in their first home game of the Indian Premier League here on Friday.

It was a uninspiring start for CSK in their opener against Rajasthan Royals. CSK, now a team full of youngsters, did not get anything right in Guwahati and would simply like to leave that comprehensive defeat behind in a long tournament such as the IPL.

Considering how the Chennai surface played in the recent T20 World Cup, it should be a good batting wicket for the game on Friday.

While the injured MS Dhoni did not travel to Guwahati, he could be back in the dugout as a sounding board to captain Ruturaj Gaikwad while he nurses a calf strain. Sanju Samson, their biggest signing for the season, did not last long on his CSK debut and would be looking to make a big impact in front of home fans.

CSK did not have the services of their key batter Dewald Brevis against Royals and there is still no clarity over



his recovery from a side strain. Sarfaraz Khan was brought into the field as an impact player following the batting collapse. He did not last long but looked comfortable in the middle in his first IPL game since 2023 season.

More will be expected from youngsters like Kartik Sharma as the tournament progresses. On the bowling front, the likes of Matt Henry and Noor Ahmad were made to look ordinary by the sheer belligerence of Vaibhav Sooryavanshi. They would be itching to bounce back from that pasting. CSK

take on last year's finalists Punjab Kings, who have become a formidable unit in the Shreyas Iyer-Ricky Ponting era.

As they aim to go all the way this season, they have found an able number three in Cooper Connolly who anchored a tense chase against Gujarat Titans on Tuesday night.

The middle-order wobbled in what should have been a straightforward chase and that will push the team to produce a more convincing performance with the bat.

This is just the beginning of Shami's road to redemption, says Pujara

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

This is just the beginning of Mohammed Shami's road to redemption, said former India batter Cheteshwar Pujara on Thursday, referring to the veteran seamer's miserly spell for Lucknow Super Giants in their IPL match against Delhi Capitals.

The out-of-favour India pacer was acquired by LSG for 10 crore in a trade with Sunrisers Hyderabad during the pre-auction window. Shami marked his LSG debut by becoming the first bowler in IPL history to claim five first-ball wickets, dismissing K L Rahul in their 2026 season opener.



Speaking about Shami's effort against DC, Pujara told broadcaster Star Sports, "This season of the IPL is very important for Mohammed Shami and the way he started off the tournament with this perfor-

mance against DC shows he means business.

"Yes, his figures read 1 for 28, but it was Shami who played a crucial role in helping his side get off to a strong start in the power-play. He first got rid of KL Rahul on the very first ball of the run chase and full credit to Shami."

Despite the six-wicket loss to Delhi Capitals, Shami's opening spell highlighted his form following a 67-wicket domestic season.

He knew that Rahul loves to play the inside out shot, so he bowled a wide delivery. Rahul played the inside out shot but it went straight into the hands of the deep point fielder.

Proteas batter brings curtains down on international career

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Johannesburg

Left out of this year's centrally-contracted list, South Africa batter Rassie van der Dussen on Thursday announced his international retirement without specifying any reasons but said he will remain available for his domestic side Lions.

The 37-year-old from Johannesburg, who hasn't turned up in national colours since March last year, played 18 Tests, 71 ODIs and 57 T20 Internationals after making his debut in 2018 as a 29-year-old.

"It is with a proud heart and a profound sense of gratitude that I announce



my retirement from international cricket," van der Dussen said in a statement on 'X'.

To wear the Proteas jersey is a feat that demands a level of resilience and dedication that both tests, and rewards you in the most incredible way.



Nakamura slams FIDE's anti-cheating protocols at Candidates

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

American Grandmaster Hikaru Nakamura has slammed the International Chess Federation (FIDE) for its stringent anti-cheating measures at the ongoing Candidates Tournament in Cyprus, calling them "complete nonsense".

The world number two expressed his frustration when asked about the anti-cheating measures at the elite tournament to determine D Gukesh's challenger for the world championship later this year. He said the scanners and machines around the playing area have made the players feel like Mossad (Israeli intelligence) agents operating inside Iran.

"My general view about the whole topic of delay, cheating over the board, all that stuff is that I frankly think it's nonsense," Nakamura said.

THUSHARA SEEKS COURT INTERVENTION TO PLAY IN IPL

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Colombo

Sri Lankan fast bowler Nuwan Thushara on Thursday sought a court order to secure his playing rights in the ongoing IPL after the country's cricket board refused to grant him a No Objection Certificate due to "failed fitness tests".

The 31-year-old, who is contracted to Royal Challengers Bengaluru, filed a case in the Colombo District Court, seeking an order directing Sri Lanka Cricket to issue the NOC.



Pakistan weightlifting chief, coach banned for life

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Lausanne

The Court of Arbitration for Sport's Anti-Doping Division (CAS ADD) has imposed a life ban on suspended Pakistan Weightlifting Federation chief Hafiz Imran Butt and coach Irfan Butt for their involvement in the administration of banned substances to the country's athletes, including minors, between 2014 and 2016.

Pakistani weightlifter Abubakar Ghani has also been handed a four-year ban for submitting falsified medical prescriptions to explain failed dope tests. Ghani had tested positive for the prohibited hormone and metabolic modulator Tamoxifen metabolite during the 2021 World Championships in Tashkent.



In its judgement indicting Hafiz and Irfan, the CAS-ADD stated, "...both athlete support personnel had been directly involved in the administration of prohibited substances, including steroids, to Pakistani athletes, including minors, and had played central roles in large-scale doping in Pakistan."

Goa, Bengal, Chandigarh, Uttarakhand win

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Ranchi

Goa, Bengal, Chandigarh and Uttarakhand won their respective matches on the second day of the Sub Junior Women's National Hockey Championship here on Thursday.

Goa beat Telangana 6-3 in a Division C Pool A match, Bengal defeated Dadra and Nagar Haveli & Daman and Diu 1-0 in Division B Pool A game, while Chandigarh crushed Gujarat 12-1 in a Division B Pool B match.

Uttarakhand got the better of Karnataka 6-1 in another Division B Pool B match.

Captain Dellina Mendes (40th minute, 41st) and Bertila Kerketta



(48th, 52nd) scored a brace each for Goa, while Seema Tirkey (3rd) and

Vidya Kumari (16th) also contributed with goals.